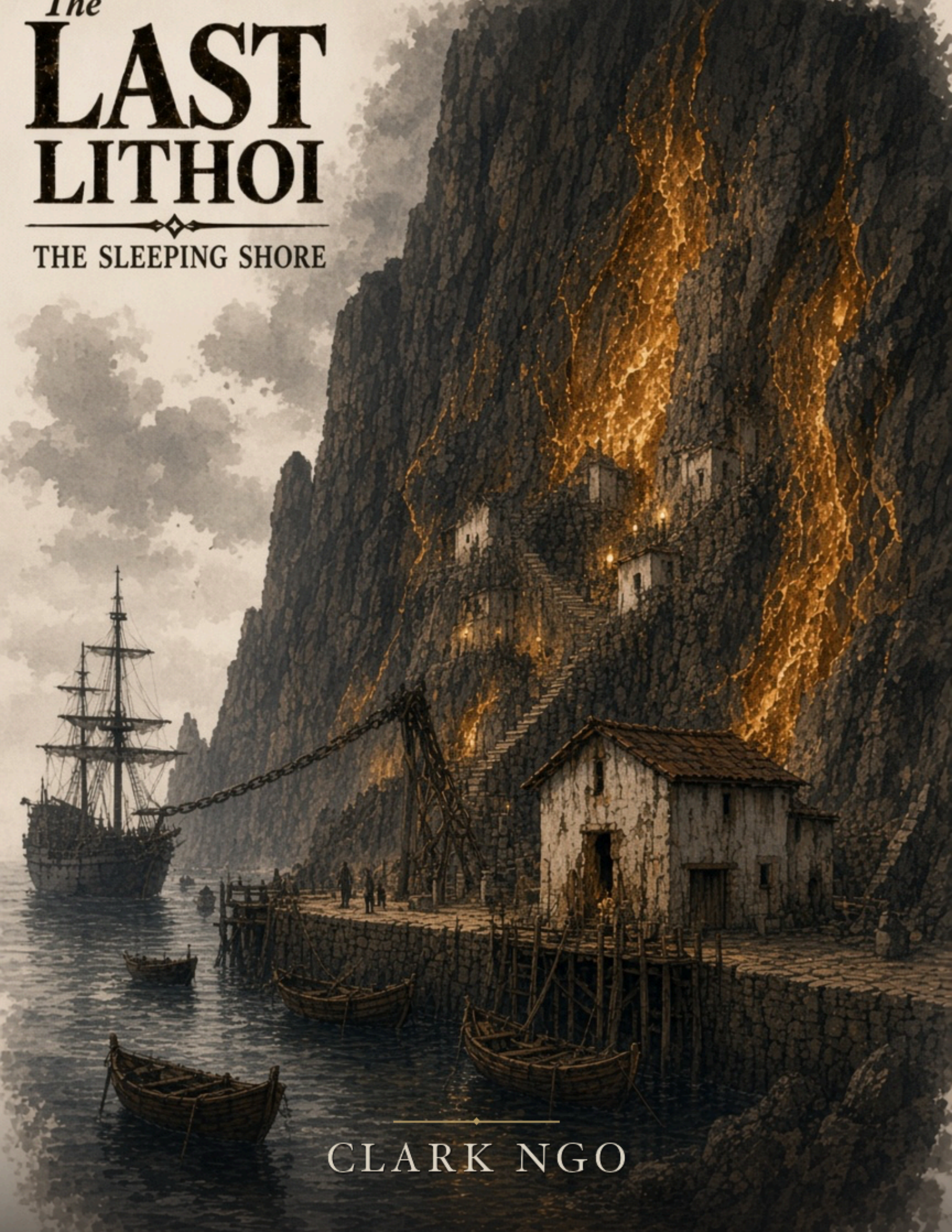
The

LAST LITHOI

THE SLEEPING SHORE



CLARK NGO

The Last Lithoi

Clark Ngo

Contents

Dramatis Personae — Book Four 1
New to This Book's Ledger 2
A Note on the Territory — Book Four 3
Chapter One — Twenty-Two Days 4
Chapter Two — The Deep Ledger 8
Chapter Three — The Honey-Colored Stone 12
Chapter Four — What the Fragments Never Said 16
Chapter Five — Terms 21
Chapter Six — The Girl Who Learned to Wait 26
Chapter Seven — Names for What She Is 30
Chapter Eight — The Cliff Road 34
Chapter Nine — The Names 39
Chapter Ten — The Name She Chose 43
Chapter One — The Grey Sail 47
Chapter Two — What Hask Fears 51
Chapter Three — The Cradle Rite 55
Chapter Four — Grown, Not Touched 60
Chapter Five — The Case File of the Sleeping 64
Chapter Six — Forty-One 68
Chapter Seven — Three Hundred Years 72
Chapter Eight — What Reth Offers 76
Chapter Nine — The Storm Season 81
Chapter Ten — The Third Pocket 85
Chapter Eleven — What the Coast Remembers 89
Chapter Twelve — The Salt Coast, Wider 93

Dramatis Personae — Book Four

Characters carried forward from earlier books are described here as who this book finds them. See the Book Three list for their earlier shape.

CAELEN — a decade and more on from the mountain, and sailing, for the first time, toward a child in the amber instead of away from one. Spends the book learning that the thing he has banked every hour of his life was never an enemy, and what it costs to set it down.

ROOK — the same fast tongue, seasick for twenty-two days and still the first to say the true thing plainly. Pays for this book in one ear.

SERAPHINA — archivist of the rite. Finds out what it was always for, and that three books of work were exactly right and only half the song.

MALAKAR — reads a Guild appendix the way he once read a case file, for what the language was built to hide.

CORWIN — second son, mender of one cuff, first-time sailor. Learns what the sea looks like when it does not end, and what a wrist is for.

THE GIRL — nine years old or thereabouts, found sealed in honey stone, awake and without a name or a language anyone could hear. Chooses both for herself.

TAMSIN ORRE — tide-clerk of the third harbor, twenty-two, keeper of a pencil log inside her sash. The first thing the girl saw. Learns, late, that carrying the tray was not the same as sitting down.

ONDREI VESH — Harbor-Master and Keeper of the Deep Ledger. Dressed in his best coat for a hearing he was afraid of. Spent nineteen years keeping the dead before learning he had been keeping a nursery.

BRINE-REEVE HASK — head of the harbor council and keeper of the door. Not a cruel man, a careful one, and afraid, with reason, of being wrong.

CLERK-SUPERIOR IBB — seventy, bone-thin, taught Tamsin her letters. Wanted the sleepers holy and found they were only alive.

NESSA — keeper of twenty-two lamps. Her mother kept them before her.

In memoriam

ANSEL, forge-keeper of Hollow Cut. **VARRICK**, scavenger, who did not look back. **FENN**, brass-fitter, who finished it properly. **YSOLT MARR**, tide-clerk, dismissed for conduct, who sat with a sleeper and hummed.

New to This Book's Ledger

CHAIRMAN RETH *(returning)* — still in a plain grey coat, still right about the numbers. Sails to the Salt Coast to stop a charge he has been told he cannot stop.

ENGINEER-CAPTAIN HALSE — square, sandy, courteous, sincere. Disobeys the way a very reasonable man does, and is the first to ask to be locked up.

Do not break. Do not hurry. A broken cradle breaks the child.

— carved in a spiral of tonal characters on the wall of the Honey Chapel, third harbor; transcribed from a nine-year-old's hum, authorship unrecorded

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So they're not in the dark.

— lamp-keeper's answer, Salt Coast, when asked why a light is trimmed nightly for a sleeper who cannot see it

A Note on the Territory — Book Four

(Supplements the earlier territory notes. This account covers only the ground this book adds: the Salt Coast, three weeks by sea from the Spire.)

The sea has no ground to read, and this account will not pretend otherwise. It records only what its keepers consider worth the ink.

The crossing takes twenty-two days from the Spire's port in fair weather, and is dangerous after the first autumn gales, which in the year of this book arrived a month early.

The Salt Coast is a long black seaboard whose cliffs are banded with honey-colored stone. It has no great cities. Its people mine by lantern and rope at low water, never at scale, and keep a record of everything they pull from the cliffs.

The third harbor is built on a stair: ledge over ledge of whitewashed houses climbing a cliff from the quay, joined by flights of black steps, with a boom chain laid on the bottom since before the oldest Ledger and raised only for storms.

The tide-house stands on stilts at the head of the stair, with the sea running beneath it twice a day. It holds the **Deep Ledger**: hundreds of oiled-sailcloth volumes, one for every year, recording every body ever drawn from the cliffs.

The cliff road runs north along the headland, swept shell and gravel edged with white stones, lit by forty-one small tin lamps in niches at the cliff's lip. Nobody walks it. Somebody sweeps it.

The Honey Chapel lies at the head of the road: a whitewashed passage forty paces long, and, at its end, a natural chamber whose walls are veined with luminous stone and carved with a spiral nobody read for three hundred years.

The pockets have names, given by the harbor and not by any survey: the Weeping Stair, the Long Shelf, the Heron's Knee, Nessa's Dip, the Drowned Bell, the Cradle Hole, the Old Mouth. There are forty-one. The Ledger's margin counts a hundred and nine sleepers among them.

The Teeth are a line of rocks beyond the harbor mouth where the sea breaks white in a gale. Boats have been lost there since the harbor was founded.

Neither this account nor any before it has mapped the country whole. It notes only that Halse's survey names four hundred and eleven seams with a periodic pulse along the western seaboard, and that no one knows how many are occupied.

Chapter One — Twenty-Two Days

The sea had no ground to read, and by the third morning Caelen had stopped trying.

For ten years the land had answered him before he asked. The mine had, and the Wastes, and the old range with its patient seam. Even the pale country north of the Wastes had gone mute under his feet only a little at a time, and he had learned to walk it by eye like anyone else. The ocean did not go mute. It simply never spoke. It moved under the keel in long grey swells with nothing buried in them, and when he put his palm flat against the deck rail and reached for the shape of what lay below, he found only cold water going down and down and down, and a sense of enormous indifference.

“You’re doing it again,” Rook said, from the bottom of the companionway.

“Doing what?”

“Looking at the floor like you’re waiting for it to say something.” Rook was the color of old tallow. He had a bucket in one hand and a heel of dry bread in the other, and he held both with equal suspicion. “It’s a boat, Caelen. It’s wood. It’s not going to tell you anything. It’s going to go up and then it’s going to go down, and I’m going to die in the interval.”

“You’re not going to die.”

“Tell my stomach.” He sat down heavily on the lowest step. “Years in the Wastes, and I thought I knew every way a body could be miserable.”

Caelen crouched in front of him and took the bread out of his hand, broke it in half, and gave him back the smaller piece. Then he took a strip of dried meat from his coat and set it on the step between them, the way he had once been taught to set down an offer. Rook looked at it for a long moment.

"That's cheating," he said.

"It's eating." He waited. After a while Rook took the meat, and chewed it with the grim concentration of a man defusing something, and kept it down.

The ship was called the *Patience of Aldous*, a broad-hulled hall vessel with a patched mainsail and a captain who spoke to the weather as though it were a junior clerk. Maren had arranged it in four days, which Corwin said was either a miracle or a threat. She had put a sealed letter of standing in Seraphina's hand and a purse of the hall's silver in Malakar's, and had stood on the quay in the grey dawn with her robe slightly too large and said, "I will be wrong about a great deal while you are gone. I should like you to know that I intend to ask."

Orell had not come. He stood on the quay beside her with his arms folded, a big grey man in an apron somebody had forgotten to take off him, and said that the house at Kesh Hollow had nine Captains in it now, three of whom were not yet sleeping, and that someone ought to be there who had worn the uniform. He had gripped Malakar's forearm once, hard. He had said nothing at all to Caelen, and then, at the last moment, had said, "Tell the girl somebody on this side of the water is holding a bed for her." Caelen had not known what to say, and so had nodded.

Lisbet was at the Spire, running the house with the green door. She had written them a letter of her own, two lines long, in the small clear hand she had signed a witness roll with. *Come back. The kettle is on.* Corwin had it folded in his breast pocket and took it out on the second day to read it, and on the fifth, and on the ninth, with the air of a man checking that a limb was still attached.

He had never seen open water. He stood at the bow every morning in his good grey coat, with the green ribbon in his buttonhole going stiff with salt, and watched the horizon with an expression of such naked, undefended wonder that Caelen sometimes had to look away. "It doesn't *end,*" he said, on the fourth day, to nobody. "I knew it didn't end. I've read the books. I had not understood that it doesn't *end.*"

"You'll get used to it," said Malakar, behind him.

"I hope not," Corwin said.

Malakar was the surprise. He had been at sea precisely never, and had been braced, Caelen thought, for the same dry misery Rook had, with the same stoic Warden's resolve. Instead he had walked up the gangplank, set his hand on the rail, and gone entirely still. By the second evening he was up in the rigging with the first mate, being shown how a topsail was reefed, with the intent, meticulous delight of a man who has spent twenty years among stone and file cabinets and has just been told that there is another way to be in the world. He had stopped saying *precisely* and started saying *oh.* He had a blister on his palm and refused to have it dressed.

"I had thought," he told Caelen one night, on the quarterdeck, with the stars going out like lamps down the whole length of the sky, "that I had a very good understanding of the size of things. That is what an Inquisitor's work is. One learns to measure." He shook his head slowly. "I should like it noted that I have been entirely wrong."

Seraphina did not sleep either. They found each other, most nights, at the stern rail around the middle watch, where the wake spread behind the ship in a long white scar that closed over almost at once.

She had the Salt Coast letter with her. She had read it so often the creases had gone soft as cloth, and she kept it in her coat pocket, where the shard had once ridden and her father's letter after it, and took it out only to look at the signature.

"*Ondrei Vesh,*" she said, on the twelfth night. "Harbor-Master and Keeper of the Deep Ledger. A man who writes a request for help in the passive voice and signs it with every title he has." She smiled slightly. "I like him already. He is frightened and he has dressed for it."

"What do you think we'll find?"

"I think that I do not know." She said it simply, and it cost her something visible. "I have spent three years being the person who knows what the fragments say. It is a very odd sensation to sail toward a thing that I have not read." She turned the letter over. "*She does not seem to have a language.* Do you understand what that means? Not that she is silent. Not that she is frightened. That in all of her waking, nobody has found the thing in her that speaks."

"She spoke to me once," Caelen said. "In the mine. Before anything else."

Seraphina turned.

"Not in words. There wasn't any word. There was a pulse, and I knew it, and it knew me. That was all there was." He watched the wake close. "I don't think she'll have language, Seraphina. I think she'll have that. And I think the first thing anyone has done to her is try to teach her to be something else."

He lay awake, when the others slept, and listened to the sea.

It took him until the sixteenth night to understand what he was listening to. The tide did not run on this crossing, not in the shallow way it did at a harbor. But the swell had a rhythm under all its violence, a long slow rise and fall that came up through the keel and the planking and the bunk-frame into his spine, and it was too regular to be wind. It was a pulse. It went on and on, slow and patient, as it must have gone on since before there were any people to hear it. He lay in the dark with his palm on the hull and felt the whole sea breathing, and was nine years old, and curled tight in a warm dark that held him, and had a name that was a small stone.

He did not move for a long time.

On the eighteenth day he told Rook, who had by then graduated to keeping down a whole biscuit.

"You're afraid," Rook said, flatly.

"I'm —" He stopped. "Yes."

"Of what? She's a kid, Caelen."

“I know what she is.” He had gone over it a hundred times, in a hundred versions of the dark. “That’s the trouble. I know exactly what she is. She’s what I was, and I don’t know what to say to her. Varrick had something. He’d say *come down, eat,* and walk off, and I’d follow. But I’ve been trying to remember what it was, and it wasn’t kindness. It wasn’t a method. It was a man who didn’t look back to see if I was coming.”

“So don’t look back.”

“She isn’t going to follow a stranger down a ridge. She’s in a locked room.”

“Then you’re not Varrick.” Rook shrugged, a tired, ordinary, brotherly gesture. “You’ve spent a year thinking you have to be him. That’s the trap, I think. You’ve got to be what the person in front of you needs, and you don’t know yet what that is. So don’t pick. Go in. Sit down. Wait.”

“That’s all?”

“That’s what he did.” Rook picked a crumb off his sleeve. “You said it yourself. He left meat on a stone and he waited. You think that was *nothing?*”

On the twenty-first night the wind changed.

It came round to the south and brought a smell with it, brine and weed and woodsmoke and something under it that was warm and mineral and sweet, and Caelen came up on deck without deciding to. He stood at the rail in the dark. The others were already there, silent in a loose row. Corwin had his face turned into the wind like a dog. Malakar had one hand on a stay. Seraphina stood very straight with her coat pulled close.

There was nothing to see. There was a low line of black along the edge of the world, a shade darker than the sky, and over it, faint and scattered, a few lights that might have been stars or lanterns.

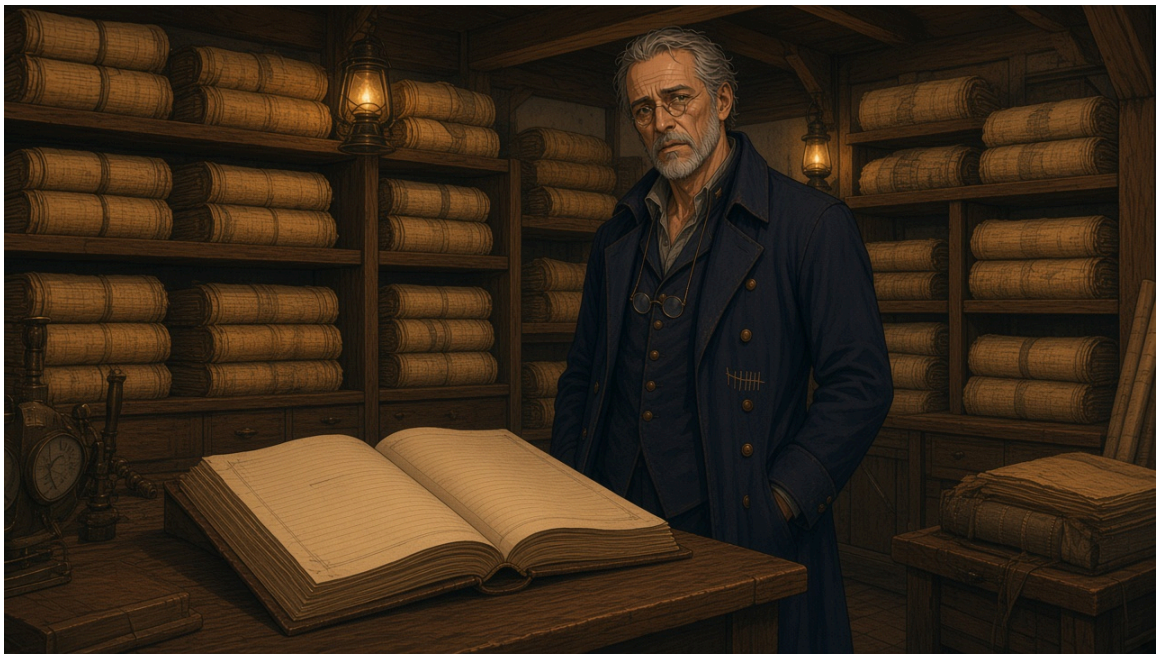
But the warm sweet smell was the smell of the shard, of the Vault, of the chamber under a mountain. It came across twenty-two days of open water and settled in the back of his throat, and he understood that she could smell it too. She had been breathing it for weeks in a room above a harbor. It was the only thing in the whole strange world that she knew.

Come down, he thought. *Eat.*

It was not a speech. He turned it over and could make nothing larger of it. It was a sentence a man had said once to a boy in a tree, with dry meat on a flat stone, and it had been enough to change a life.

He put his hand on the rail and watched the lights come up out of the dark, one by one, and did not look away, and did not look back.

Chapter Two — The Deep Ledger



The third harbor was built on a stair.

Caelen saw it from the deck as the *Patience* came round the headland in the grey first light: a black cliff dropping straight into green water, and cut into its face, ledge over ledge, a town of whitewashed houses that climbed from the quay to the clifftop like a held breath. There were no streets. There were flights of black stone steps, hundreds of them, zigzagging up between the roofs, and fishing boats tarred dark as seals bobbing along the foot of the wall. The whole place smelled of brine and wet rope and woodsmoke, and under it, faint and sweet, of the warmth he had tasted on the wind the night before.

The cliff itself was banded. At low tide, with the sea drawn back from its foot, the black rock showed long streaks of honey-colored stone running through it like veins in meat, some as thin as a finger, some as wide as a door. He stood at the rail with his hand flat on the wood and felt the whole headland hum.

“It’s everywhere,” Seraphina said quietly, beside him.

“Yes.”

“No wonder they stopped counting.”

Nobody greeted them with a cheer. That was the first thing. The *Patience* came alongside a stone quay thick with people, fishers and net-menders and women with salt-cracked hands, and they all stood very still and watched the gangplank go down. Nobody shouted. A child began to speak and was hushed. Caelen came ashore behind Malakar with his coat open and the empty brass housing at his wrist where anyone could see it, and the quiet that followed him down the plank had a shape, and the shape was care.

He had been looked at by strangers for most of a year now, on the Spire road and in the Hall of Canon, and he had learned the difference between wonder and the other thing. This was the other thing. An old man by a pile of lobster pots touched two fingers to a mark scratched on the quay stones, a little line with a notch cut in it, and then looked away. A woman gathered a boy against her skirt. Nobody was unkind. Everybody was watching what he did with his hands.

The Brine-Reeve met them at the foot of the first stair.

He was a broad man of sixty in a salt-stiffened coat, with heavy lids and a face like something the weather had been working on a long time. Two clerks in blue stood a pace behind him. He did not smile, but he bowed, exactly as far as the visitors' rank required, and said in a deep slow voice, "Hask. Brine-Reeve of the third harbor. You are welcome. You will find us an honest people." A pause. "We have had practice."

"I'm Caelen."

"I know who you are, sir." He did not look at Caelen's chest, and the effort of not looking was obvious. "The wool factor carried your broadsides up the coast in the spring. There is a song, I understand. It is not a good one." His eyes moved over the others, one by one, pricing nothing, missing nothing. "The Harbor-Master asked for you. I did not. I want that said plainly on the quay, in front of witnesses, so that nobody afterward can say the Reeve of this harbor lied to his guests."

"That's plain," said Malakar, in the voice he used for documents.

"Good." Hask stepped aside and gestured up the stair. "Then you may go up. Vesh is waiting. You will find the house at the top of the third flight set aside for you. It has a good fire." He paused. "It has a good lock, also. You will forgive that. We do not know you."

It was, Caelen thought, climbing, the most honest hospitality he had ever been offered, and the most frightening.

The tide-house stood at the top of the stair on stilts, with the sea running under it twice a day, and its door was low enough that Corwin had to stoop. Inside, it was a single long room with a floor of black oak and tall windows on three sides. It smelled of ink, and lamp oil, and damp paper. Along every wall, from floor to rafter, were shelves, and on the shelves, lying flat, were books.

They were bound in oiled sailcloth, hundreds of them, each as thick as a man's forearm, with a year inked on the spine in white. At the far end of the room a lectern held one open, and beside it, in a straight-backed chair, a spare man in a dark blue harbor coat sat with his hands folded on his knee, waiting.

He rose as they entered. He was perhaps fifty-five, thin as a rake, with spectacles on a cord and a close grey beard trimmed with great care. The coat had brass buttons, each one stamped with a tiny tally mark. He had dressed, Caelen saw, for an audience. He had put on his best coat and brushed it, and then, plainly, had been unable to stop his hands from shaking.

“Ondrei Vesh,” he said. “Harbor-Master of the third harbor, and Keeper of the Deep Ledger. I wrote the letter. You are the archivist, I think.” He bowed to Seraphina. “And you, sir, I will not guess.”

“Caelen.”

“Yes.” Vesh looked at him for a long moment through the spectacles, and something moved across his exact dry face and was put away. “I should like to see the letter of standing, if you will permit me. I do not doubt it. It is a habit.”

Seraphina gave it to him. He read it twice, with the patient suspicion of a man checking a lock. He turned it over. He held the seal to the light, and smelled the wax, and compared the hand on the outside with a card of something in his pocket. Then he nodded and folded it away. “The Eldest of the Hall of Canon,” he said. “A Custodian named Maren. I had not heard the name.”

“She has not held the chair long.”

“It shows. The letter is very clear.” He said it without sarcasm. “I find that clarity in new officers is a kind of fear.”

He turned back to Caelen, and his voice dropped.

“I will ask one thing, and I ask you not to be offended. The broadsides say that you were once what is in my third harbor. That you were found in the stone.”

“Yes.”

“Say it aloud. In this room. Not for me.” He gestured at the shelves. “For the record. The Ledger does not accept what it has not been told.”

Caelen looked at the books, hundreds of them, spine on spine, and understood what this place was. It was a cemetery. It was a cemetery that had written itself down, a harbor’s whole long grief in white ink, every body drawn from every cliff. He had stood at a lectern in a vault in the Spire and been asked to say his name. He had not expected to be asked, here, to say what he was.

“I was found in the stone,” he said. “Ten years ago, in a mine, at the bottom of a strata the Guild hadn’t mapped. I was nine. I’d been there as long as I could remember.” He swallowed. “I don’t know who put me there, or why. I’d like to find out.”

Vesh nodded slowly. “Thank you.” He took off his spectacles and wiped them on his sleeve, and when he put them back on, his eyes behind them were brighter than they had been. “I should like it recorded that I wrote the letter because the coast’s doctrine had nothing left to try. I should also like it recorded that I would rather not have.”

He gave them terms. Of course he did.

They sat at a long table under the windows, with salt fish and good bread and a pot of black tea, and Vesh laid them out as he might have laid out a tide table. No one was to leave the harbor without the council’s knowledge. No instrument, no charge, no tool of the Guild or the hall was to be carried into the galleries. The girl would not be moved. The girl would not be taken from the third harbor under any circumstances, by any authority, for any reason, and if the visitors

were not prepared to swear to that, they might take the *Patience* home that evening, with the harbor's thanks.

"We swear it," said Seraphina.

"You haven't heard the rest."

"I know what the rest will be." She said it gently. "It will be that she is a person. We were not coming to take her."

"There are people who come to take." Vesh poured the tea with great precision. "I have watched them, Archivist. The Guild came eight years ago with a survey. The Synod came twice with a clerk who wanted to see the Ledger, and left with a list of what he wished to keep. I do not accuse you. I am explaining why the Reeve has put a lock on your door." A thin smile. "I am not the Reeve's friend, in general. But I find that I cannot fault the lock."

"We understand terms," Caelen said.

Vesh looked at him for a while.

"I believe you do," he said. "It is an odd quality, in a man of your history. I had expected something else."

"What?"

"Gratitude," Vesh said. "Or hunger. Most of the people who come to us from the great places have one or the other." He stood. "Come. I will show you the entry. Then I will send you to your fire, and tomorrow you will meet the child."

The Deep Ledger of the third harbor was kept in a book of its own. Vesh took it from a locked case, not from the shelves, a thick volume bound in new sailcloth and not yet gone grey. He laid it on the lectern and opened it to a page near the back.

It was ruled in columns. A date. A tide. A depth, in fathoms. A gallery, with a name: *the Weeping Stair.* A condition, in the neat angular hand of a harbor clerk. And there, in the middle of the page, under the heading **Name,** a line.

The line was blank.

Caelen read the entry through twice. *Third harbor. Dark of the year, low water, spring tide. Weeping Stair, seam six, thirty-one fathoms. One body, living. Child, approx. nine years. Found sealed in honey stone. Condition: sealed.* Below it, in a different, smaller hand, a later entry: *Woke, early spring. Condition: awake. Does not speak. Hums.*

He put one finger on the blank line. The paper was warm. It had been warm from the lamp, he told himself. It had been warm from the room.

"I could not write her a name," Vesh said, quietly, behind him. "I tried. It seemed a theft. Every body that has ever been pulled from these cliffs had a name already, whether we knew it or no.

The Ledger records what it is told. It does not make up names for the dead." He stopped. "She is not dead. I do not know what the Ledger does with her."

"What do you call her?"

"In the book, *the Sleeper*. The clerks call her the girl." A very small breath. "She does not answer to either."

Caelen stood a while longer with his finger on the blank line, and below him, through the black oak floor of the tide-house, the tide came in. He felt it come: first as sound, a long hush under the stilts, and then as something else. The whole building rose and settled on the swell like a ship at anchor. The pulse he had felt through the hull for twenty-two days came up through the floor and into his boots, slow, regular, vast.

And under it, so faint that he thought at first he had imagined it, there was another. Higher. Thinner. Somewhere in the white houses above them, a small hum reached down through the cliff and found him, and held his note for one long breath, and let it go.

Chapter Three — The Honey-Colored Stone

The girl had been given the highest room in the harbor, and Caelen understood why before he reached the top of the stair.

It was the only room in the whole town that the tide could not reach. The house stood at the head of the fourth flight, a narrow whitewashed building leaning against the cliff like a tired man against a wall, and its single upper window looked out over the roofs and the green water to the open sea. Someone had thought about that. Someone had decided that a child pulled from thirty-one fathoms of dark ought to wake to a view.

“It was the Reeve’s idea, the room,” said Tamsin Orre, climbing ahead of him with one hand trailing on the wall. “He’s not a cruel man. I want you to know that before you decide what you think of us. He’s a careful one, and he took one look at her and put her where he could see the harbor and the harbor could see her.”

“Can she see it?”

“She doesn’t look.” She stopped on a landing and turned. “She doesn’t look at much. She looks at the walls, mostly. She puts her hands on them.”

She was twenty-two, he guessed, or nearly. She had a tide-clerk’s blue sash tied over a plain grey dress, the knot too tight, the ends frayed, and ink-stain to the second knuckle on both hands. Her hair was a short dark braid with a pencil stuck through it. She had a narrow, freckled, stubborn face, and she looked at Caelen the way Rook had looked at him at the stall in Hollow Cut: straight on, and not at all impressed. He liked her at once, and he was wary of that.

“The others will wait below,” she said. “Vesh was clear. It’s you, and it’s me, and the door stays open. If she goes under the bed, you don’t go after her. If she makes the sound, you don’t speak. And if she comes toward you —” She hesitated. “I don’t know what to tell you, if she comes toward you. She hasn’t, with anyone.”

“Not even you?”

“Not even me.” A small hard breath. “I’ve been three months on that stair. I carry up the tray. She’s never once taken it from my hand.”

There was a bar across the outside of the door. Someone had wound blue ribbon around it, to make it look like a decoration, and it only made it worse.

Tamsin lifted it down without a word and propped the door wide with her hip, and Caelen stood at the threshold and looked into the room.

It had been made, with enormous care and no idea, into a nursery. The walls were washed pale yellow. Someone had painted stars on the ceiling, a hundred of them, gold on blue, with one of the clerks’ careful numbers inked beside each. There was a small bed with a patchwork quilt, and a carved wooden horse with a missing ear, and a low shelf of picture books in four languages, none of which had been opened. A tray of food stood on the floor by the door, bread and boiled egg and a bowl of something warm, untouched, with a thin skin on it. The window had a lattice across it, pretty, wrought iron in the shape of waves. It was a lock.

The room was empty.

Then he saw the nest. In the far corner, under the window, every blanket in the house had been dragged into a heap and packed down hard against the wall, with a gap at the top just wide enough for a small body. And on the walls above it, in a wide scatter at the height of a small child’s reach, were handprints.

They were pressed into the whitewash. They had not been painted; there was no color to them. They were smooth, shallow depressions, like prints in clay, as if the plaster itself had softened for

a moment and taken the shape of a palm and then hardened again. Dozens of them. They were slightly browner than the wall around them. When he stepped nearer, he felt it before he saw it: heat, a faint steady warmth, coming off each one.

"She does it when she's frightened," Tamsin said, from the door. "Or lonely. I can't tell which."

He did not answer. He had stopped three paces from the nest. His heart was going hard and slow. A hum had started in the room, so soft that he took it first for the sea, the long tide-pulse under the whole town. But it was higher than the sea and it was not steady. It rose and fell, a small, thin, wandering note that wound through the blankets like thread through cloth.

He had last heard it in the dark under a mountain. He had been inside it.

Sit down, he thought. *Wait.*

He sat.

He did it slowly, cross-legged on the bare boards with his hands loose on his knees, a good arm's length beyond the edge of the nest. He did not look into the gap. He looked at the wall, at the nearest of the handprints, and let his breath go long.

For a long time nothing happened. The hum wound on, soft, uneven. The tide ran in under the house. A gull went past the window and its shadow swept across the quilt. Caelen did not move. His left knee had begun to ache and he let it.

Then the blankets shifted.

It was a very small movement. A fold sagged and rose. A single hand came out of the gap, the fingers long and fine, the nails cut short and ragged, and rested on the floor, and he saw that the skin of it was faintly honeyed, a tint under the ordinary brown, like candlelight through a cup. The hand stayed there a while. Then it drew back.

He still did not look. He heard her breathing now, quick and shallow, and the faint rasp of wool on wool, and then a long, long stillness.

When she came out, she came out low.

She came out on all fours, fast, pressed to the floor like something that expected to be struck, and stopped halfway across the boards with her weight on her hands. She was small. She was smaller than he had imagined, thin as a fence-rail in a grey smock somebody had cut down from a man's shirt, with her hair hacked short around a face that was all eyes. They were very large, and they were not dark. Even in the pale daylight from the window they held the light and threw it back, a faint green-gold sheen like a cat's in a doorway.

Caelen made himself breathe. The old animal in him said *run,* and the old animal in him knew exactly what she was seeing, because he had been there.

She did not look at his face.

He had braced for that. He had told himself it would be the first thing, the hard bright assessing stare of someone deciding if a stranger was safe. But her eyes went past his face as if it were weather. They went to his chest.

They stayed there. Her head tipped, a quarter-inch, then another. Her nostrils flared. The hum in her throat, which had never stopped, changed.

It was not a thing he did. He would be sure of that afterward, lying awake, going over it. He had not reached for the coal. He had not lit it. For years he had held it banked and sullen behind his sternum, and he held it so even now, unlit, the heat of a stone left out in the sun.

But it answered her.

He felt it stir. He felt a small, bright, wordless thread of heat run up out of the bank like smoke from an ember, and the note in her throat and the note in his chest met. They did not meet like a sound and an echo. They met like two hands. For one long breath they held the same pitch, hers thin and high, his deep, a perfect octave apart, and the whole whitewashed room seemed to ring. The handprints on the wall brightened. Beside the nest, the floorboard she was touching began, very slowly, to warm.

Then she moved her note. A half-step, no more. And his followed, as though she had pulled a string.

She's leading, he thought, with a cold drop of understanding. *She isn't answering me. She's testing what I'll do.*

She moved it again, and he followed again, and a third time, a small deliberate dance of tones, and somewhere in the third he understood what was happening, and it was worse than anything he had braced for. She was not finding out whether he was friendly. She was finding out what he was. She was reading the banked coal, the hunger beneath it, the long cold history of every Shift it had paid for, the way a doctor reads a pulse. She could feel all of it. Everything he had spent ten years learning to hold behind his teeth, she had picked up in one breath, as if it were a smell.

She knows.

She knew what he would become if he let go. She knew it the way he knew the shape of the dark in a flooded mine. And she was sitting there on the boards, ten feet away, with her eyes on his chest and her head tilted, humming it back to him.

He did not move. His palms were wet. The coal behind his sternum, which he had banked every hour of every day for a decade, pulsed once, hard, and he held it.

"Caelen," Tamsin said, very low, from the door. "Your hands."

He looked down. His fingers, lying on his knees, had lengthened by half an inch. The nails were gone grey and thick.

He closed his eyes. He did not reach for the stone of his name. He did not need to. He thought of a man's unhurried boots, and of a strip of dried meat on a flat rock, and of nothing at all, and let the heat sink back down into the bank, a breath at a time, until his hands were only hands.

When he opened his eyes again, she had come three feet closer.

She was sitting on her heels in the middle of the floor with her palms flat on the boards, and her eyes were no longer on his chest. They were on his face. They were the strangest eyes he had ever seen, green-gold and wide and utterly without fear, and it came to him with a slow, enormous clarity that she had not been afraid of him, in the whole of that long exchange. She had been afraid of the room.

She tilted her head the other way. She hummed one clear note, higher than before, and held it.

It was a question. He had no words for it, but it was a question, and he knew the answer, because he had been waiting twenty-two days to say it.

Yes, he hummed back, with his closed mouth, in his chest, as he'd once hummed in the dark. *Me too.*

Chapter Four — What the Fragments Never Said

A note on point of view: this chapter departs from Caelen's perspective, following Seraphina. See style-guide.md §4.

SERAPHINA

They gave her the oldest volumes in a room of their own, and a lamp that did not smoke, and an apprentice who was told to bring tea and not to speak.

She had read in worse places. She had read in a reliquary's cold vault with a clerk's eye on her back, and in a stone cell with a guard outside, and in a dry hollow in the Wastes by the light of a fire that was dying. She had never read in a room that moved. The tide-house rose and settled on its stilts every few minutes, a long gentle swell under the floor, and the lamp-flame leaned with it, and the old paper smelled of salt. By the second hour she had stopped noticing. By the fourth she was breathing in time with it.

Vesh had been explicit. *You may read what you like. You may copy what you like. You may not take the books from this room.* He had not said why. He had stood in the doorway in his best coat with his spectacles pushed up into his hair, and said, in the voice of a man who is saying one thing so as not to say another, "I would like to know what you see in them. I have read them for thirty years. I believe I have stopped seeing."

So she read.

The Deep Ledger did not keep one account. It kept two.

The first was what the harbor wrote down for itself, in columns, for three hundred years: every body drawn from every gallery, with a date, a tide, a depth, a name where one was known. It was grim and orderly work, and she understood it at once. It was the work of a people who had decided that the dead would at least be counted. The cause-of-death column used a short, sad vocabulary. *Drowned. Crushed. Fever. Fall. Exposure.* She turned the pages and let the words go by her.

The second account was in the margins.

It took her an hour to see it. It was not a record. It was a mark: a tiny upright stroke, in black ink, in the outer margin of certain pages, grouped in fives with a slash across. There was no heading. There was no explanation. The strokes appeared on page after page of the oldest volumes, in a dozen different hands over a dozen generations, so small and so regular that she had taken them for a binder's guide. When she held a page to the lamp, she saw that the strokes had not been made at the same time as the entry beside them. They had been added afterward, in a different ink, as if by someone who came back.

She counted a page. Eleven. She counted another. Four.

She set down her pen, and the pencil, and the tea she had not touched, and sat with her hands flat on the old paper for the space of three tides.

Not now, she told herself. *Read the entries first.*

There were seven.

She found the first by the cause-of-death column, because it was the only one she did not understand. *Waking.* It stood among the drownings and the falls as plainly as any of them, a word in a clerk's careful hand, as if it were a fever or a fall or a kind of weather. She looked at it for a

long moment. Then she went back through every volume, patiently, a page at a time, looking for the word.

There were seven.

The first was two hundred and ninety years back, in the first volume still legible: *A boy, nine or ten, from a seam at the Weeping Stair. Found in honey stone, by the lamp-men, at low water. Lived eleven days.* The second, ninety years after, was a girl of six. *Lived nineteen.* A boy. A girl. A boy. Two entries, in two different centuries, noted *unknown, perhaps twelve.* The longest of the seven, in the volume for the year of the Black Tide, was a girl called by the clerks only *the Stair-child,* who had lived, by the record, for forty-seven days.

She read that entry three times. It was longer than the others. It was written in a different hand, a shaky, upright, curiously tender hand, and it did not use the columns. The clerk had written it as a letter.

The clerk Ysolt Marr has asked to be recorded as having sat with her. The council has declined. I record it here regardless. She was found at the Weeping Stair, awake, with her hand on the wall. She would not eat for the first nine days. On the tenth, Ysolt sat in the room and did not speak, and on the eleventh the child took bread from her hand. She did not speak. She hummed, and Ysolt hummed back, and they did this every day for a month. On the forty-seventh day she was quiet. The clerk Ysolt Marr was removed from the harbor's service for conduct, having been found asleep at the child's side, and has not been seen since. Cause of death: waking.

Seraphina put down the page. She found that her hand was not quite steady.

Waking.

The other six had been alone. She went back over the entries and read them again, with a cold attention that she recognized, with a kind of horror, as her father's. Every one had been found by men with lamps and ropes, and taken up, and taken to a locked room and given food and water and the harbor's best regard. They had all been fed. They had all been warm. They had all been cared for by people who had no idea how to care for them. Not one of them had been sat with. They had gone quiet, one by one, over days or weeks, in rooms with painted ceilings and pretty locks, and the harbor's clerks had written down the word and put the book away.

"You've found the margin," Vesh said.

He had come in so quietly that she had not heard the door. He stood just inside it, in the dark blue coat, with his hands behind his back and his face in shadow.

"I've found the margin," she said. "I don't understand it."

"No." He crossed the room and sat in the second chair, stiffly, like a man lowering himself into cold water. "Nor do I. I have been the Keeper nineteen years. I inherited the habit with the office. When a sleeper is found, a mark goes in the margin of the oldest volume, beside the first page on which the gallery is mentioned. It is a custom. Nobody can tell me where it began." He looked at

his hands. “I have made fourteen of them. I make them at night, when the others have gone. I do not know what they are for.”

“How many are there?”

“I have never counted.”

“Vesh.”

“I *have* never counted, Archivist.” The voice cracked, very slightly, and he steadied it. “I have counted everything else in this harbor. Every net, every keel, every body. I have never counted the marks. It seemed that if I counted them, it would be a thing I knew.”

She said nothing. She sat with the old paper under her palms and the tide rocking the room, and understood that the man in front of her was frightened in a way she had not seen in a person since she had last looked in a mirror. He was not frightened of the girl. He was frightened of what the book would say if he asked it. He had spent nineteen years being a good steward of a record he could not bear to read.

I know that, she thought. *I know exactly what that is.*

“Seven,” she said, gently. “Seven waking deaths. I think you know that. I think you’ve always known the number and never let yourself say it.”

“Seven.” He closed his eyes. “Yes.”

“And the margin is more than seven.”

“I —” He stopped. “I believe it is.”

She copied the entries by hand, all seven. She copied the Stair-child’s letter word for word, and when she had finished, she sat for a long time looking at it, with the lamp burning low and the apprentice asleep on a stool by the door.

She had spent three years learning what the Synod’s fragments said. She had learned the tethering rite from half a thing: from one torn page in a reliquary nobody read, and a shard, and a boy’s body in a stone circle. She had believed, in all that time, that the rite was a medicine. It had been the only word she had for it. A cure for a wound, or, since it never cured, a way to live with one. It held a drifting mind back from the edge by giving it an anchor, a steady living presence, banked and still, to orient against.

An anchor. She had never once asked what a mind would have to be doing to need one.

She laid the Stair-child’s letter beside her own notes from the reliquary, the half-remembered fragment, the working’s opening lines, and read them together. She read the words *a presence held still, while the sleeper finds the shape of the waking.* She had translated that line, in the cold vault, as a figure of speech.

While the sleeper finds the shape of the waking.

She sat up very straight.

She did not have it. She wanted to be very clear with herself about that. She had a pattern, and a pattern was not a proof. But she had a cause-of-death column in which a Synod's worth of silence had been written out as a single word. She had seven children who had been taken from the stone and loved, correctly and carefully and entirely wrongly. And she had a line from a fragment that had always read to her like a metaphor, and did not read like one anymore.

Everyone had been so busy looking at the ending, at the drift, at the dying, that no one had asked what the stone had been *for*.

She counted before she slept. She did it on her fingers in the dark of the guest house, with the tide moving under the foundations and Corwin snoring gently through the wall, because she could not make her mind stop doing it.

The longest of the seven had lived forty-seven days.

The girl in the whitewashed room had been awake since early spring. She had been awake, by the best reckoning anyone had, for thirteen weeks. That was ninety-one days. That was nearly double the longest recorded, in three hundred years of books. She had survived a month beyond the one child who had been sat with, in a room where nobody had sat with her, in a harbor that had done everything wrong with all the kindness in the world.

Why?

She lay in the dark, listening to a pulse she could not hear, and was afraid in a way she had not been since the night her father had said *returned to the mountains.* It was not the fear of failing. She knew that fear and could stand in it. It was a different thing. It was the fear that the clock which had run out for seven children had not stopped for this one.

It was only that nobody knew how long it ran.

Chapter Five — Terms

He made it worse on the second day, and he knew exactly how.

She had come three feet toward him on the first. It had seemed like the whole road. He had lain awake that night in the guest house with the tide moving under the foundations and gone over it, step by step, and every step had looked like a victory. She had looked at his face. She had answered his note. He had spent twenty-two days wondering what to say to her, and the answer had turned out to be nothing at all, and for the space of an evening he had let himself believe that was the end of the difficulty.

So on the second morning he went up the stair with a bowl of warm porridge and a plan.

It was a good plan. It was the plan of a man who had been shown, by a hundred patient people, what care looked like and had decided to do it faster. He would sit where he had sat. He would offer the bowl. When she came near, he would hum her note, and light the coal, a little, just a thread, so she would feel the warmth in him and know it for safe. He would give her what she had given him. A conversation.

Tamsin stood at the door with her arms crossed and said nothing, which he took, at the time, for permission.

The girl came out of the blankets as soon as he sat. She came faster than the day before. She crossed the boards on all fours, quick and low, and stopped a yard away with her eyes on his chest, and he held out the bowl and hummed. It was easy. It was almost like speaking. He felt the coal answer in his sternum, small, bright, obedient, and he let it rise.

He meant it as a hand held out. He did not think about what it would feel like from the other side.

She screamed.

It was not a child's scream. It was a note, one long ragged shearing tone that went through the room and into the stone, and the handprints on the walls flared white. The lattice over the window rang like a struck bell. He felt the heat come out of the floor under his knees, and the bowl of porridge in his hand cracked in two. And she went backward across the boards in one scrambling convulsion and was under the bed before he had finished flinching, a small hot shape in the dark with her back against the wall and her eyes burning gold.

The coal was lit. He had not noticed. It had gone from a thread to a flame in the space of her cry, and when he looked down, his right hand was grey to the wrist and the porridge was boiling on the floor.

"Put it out," Tamsin said, very quietly. "Caelen. *Put it out.*"

He put it out. It took him a long time. When he had finished, there was a burn across his palm in the shape of the bowl's rim, white at the edges, and he was so cold that his teeth had started to chatter.

He had been so sure. That was the thing he kept turning over, afterward, on the stair, in the wind. He had been sure that what she wanted was to be reached. He had never once asked what it meant to a thing that could read a heartbeat to have a stranger light a fire inside it and call it kindness.

"I could have told you," Tamsin said.

They sat on the steps outside, on the third landing, with the town going about its morning below them and the tide drawn back from the foot of the cliff. Caelen held his hand out of the wind. She had wrapped it in a strip of clean linen, with a competence that told him she had done this before, for someone else.

"Why didn't you?"

"Because you'd have had to want to hear it." She shrugged. She was picking at the knot of her sash. "People come up that stair with a plan. The Reeve came with a plan. The priests came with a bell, a tide-bell, to ring her up out of the sleep. A man from the council came with a list of questions in a box. You're the fourth. You're the only one who's been burned."

"What happened to the others?"

"She hid. She hid for a day each." A short unhappy breath. "She doesn't hide from you for the same reason, I don't think. I think she's frightened of you in a different way. I think you scare her because you're like her." She looked at him sidelong. "That's a thing I noticed, I'm a clerk, I notice things. When you hummed, she didn't scream at the sound. She screamed at the *heat.*"

Caelen was silent.

"She's not the one who needs to be taught what's safe," Tamsin said. "That's all I mean. She's been awake thirteen weeks in a house full of people who all want something. She knows what safe is. She just hasn't seen it."

He turned the linen over. It was warm against his hand.

Come down, he thought. *Eat.*

It was not what he had done. He had come up the stair with a bowl and a plan and a flame. He had not once done the thing Varrick did. He had not once walked away.

On the third morning he went up the stair with nothing.

He wanted to be sure of that. He took nothing in his hands. He took a thin blanket for the cold, and a flask of water, and a strip of dried meat in his coat that he did not intend to offer, and he told Tamsin at the door what he meant to do, and she heard him out without a word.

"All day?"

"All day."

"And the next?"

"If I have to."

"The council will not like it." She was already lifting down the bar with its stupid blue ribbon. "The Reeve will ask what you're doing. I'll tell him you're listening." She stopped, and for a moment the stubborn guarded look went out of her face. "That's the truth, isn't it? That's what it is. You're listening."

"I don't know," Caelen said. "I'm going to find out."

He sat down in the same place as the first day, cross-legged, a long arm's length from the nest, and did not look at it. He looked at the wall. He did not hum. He did not reach for the coal, and when it stirred, once, in the afternoon, at some distant sound of a child's laughter in the street, he held it down with a patience he had not known he possessed. He ate his ration at noon. He drank. He sat.

The room was quiet. The tide went out and came in. The stars on the ceiling, which some clerk had painted so carefully, shone gold in the long light. He found he could count them. He found he had counted them. There were a hundred and twelve, and one of them had been painted upside down.

She did not come out. He had not expected her to. He sat in the warm yellow room, and the afternoon went over him slowly, and the light moved across the floor and up the wall, and when it was dark he lit the lamp Tamsin had left and went on sitting. At midnight he lay down on the boards with the blanket and slept as he had slept in the root-hollow of a fallen tree, folded and wary and half-awake. When the light came, he was still there.

The second day was longer. The hum started in the evening, from the nest, thin and wandering, and he did not answer it. He thought, *Don't. She's not asking.* It went on a while and stopped.

The third day was the worst, because the council came.

They came up the stair at midmorning, four of them in dark blue, with the Brine-Reeve at their head, and stood in the open doorway looking in. Caelen did not turn. He heard Hask's deep slow voice say, "He is sitting there."

"He is," said Tamsin.

"He has been sitting there two days."

"Three. He sat on the first."

"For what end?"

"I'd say he's waiting for her to be ready."

"And if she is never ready?" That was one of the others, a thin dry voice. "We have a harbor to run, Clerk. We have a doctrine. We cannot afford to keep a stranger in a locked room for the length of his patience."

Caelen did not move. He felt the whole room waiting, the clerks in the doorway and the child in the dark and the sea breathing under the house, and understood that this was the true test. Not whether the girl would come out. Whether he would turn round, and make a speech, and say, *give me time,* and become one more person who wanted something.

He kept his eyes on the wall.

"Let him sit," Hask said, finally. A long pause. "I have sat in a dark room a good many years, waiting for the sea to give something back. I have not noticed that shouting improved it." The boots shifted. "Come. We are in the way."

When the door had closed, the quiet that came after it was different. It was thicker. It had somebody in it.

The hum began again an hour later, from nearer.

He did not look. He kept his breath long and his hands open on his knees. He felt her cross the floor, that small hot presence, as clearly as if she had spoken, and stop, a yard away, and stay. He heard her breathing. It had slowed. He heard the faint scrape of a nail on the board, and the rustle of a smock.

And then he smelled it. He had not noticed it was there. It was the strip of meat, dried and salt and dark, which had fallen from his coat pocket sometime in the night and lay on the floor between them, where he had put his hand down when he stretched. He had not placed it. It had simply been left.

Let her find it, he thought. *Don't look.*

He looked at the wall. He counted stars. He got to forty, and lost his place, and started again, and somewhere in the seventies he heard her take it.

It was a very small sound. A rasp of teeth on leather. A quick wet intake of breath, and then the slow, steady, unmistakable rhythm of a child eating something she did not trust and could not

stop. It went on for a long time. He did not turn his head. He had learned to be still at a fire, and in a tree, and in a stone circle, and in none of them had it been as hard as this.

At the door, Tamsin made a sound. It was barely a breath. He did not look at her either, but he knew without turning that she had put the back of her hand to her mouth, and that she was crying, with great decorum, in the manner of a clerk who has seen a figure at last add up.

He told the room that night, because there was nobody else.

The others were asleep or pretending to be, and the girl had gone back into the blankets with her fist wrapped round the last scrap of leather. The lamp was low. He sat with his back against the wall and his burned hand in his lap, and said into the dark, in a voice just above a whisper, the words that a man had said to him once on the first night, in a rusting survey-shelter, with a fire between them.

"I don't do charity," he said. "I want to be honest about that. I don't know how. I'm going to keep you fed. You don't owe me for it. I'm not going to ask you for anything." He stopped. "That's the terms."

It sounded odd. It sounded like a thing a man says to cover another thing. He sat with it a long while.

Varrick had said *terms, not charity,* and had spent nine years not meaning it, and had told the truth at last, with a rag at his mouth, by a fire. *Might have started as arithmetic. Didn't stay that way.* He had needed the word *terms.* It had been the only door his pride would go through.

Caelen found that he did not need it. He had only needed to say it once, out loud, to know what it was.

"That's not the terms," he said softly, to the dark. "I lied. There's no terms. I'm just going to stay."

From somewhere in the blankets, thin and high and wavering, a note answered him. He did not know what it meant. He knew it was not a scream.

Chapter Six — The Girl Who Learned to Wait

A note on point of view: this chapter departs from Caelen's perspective, following Tamsin Orre — new to this series, and given an insert for the same reason Seraphina and Malakar were: the book needs her reasoning from the inside. See style-guide.md §4.

TAMSIN

She kept count of everything, and the count, on the morning the stranger first came up her stair, had been ninety-four.

It was not an important number. It was not a number the Ledger would ever want. It was simply how many days she had carried a tray up the fourth flight of the harbor stair and set it down on the boards by the door and withdrawn, as she had been taught, without speaking, with her eyes down, because that was how one approached a thing one did not understand. Ninety-four days. Two hundred and eighty-two trays. She had written every one of them in a little black book she kept inside her sash, in pencil, in a hand she had trained smaller and smaller until the page held a whole season.

Day 61. Porridge. Refused. Egg. Refused. Tried humming the third-harbor lullaby. Hid. Day 77. Brought a shell from the strand. Refused. Brought two. Refused. Day 90. Read to her for an hour from the Tide-Book. She listened to the sound. Did not listen to the sense. Hid.

She was twenty-two. She had been a tide-clerk for three years, a lamp-girl for five before that, and an orphan of the drowned for as long as she could remember. Her father's boat had gone down off the Teeth the winter she was seven, with all hands, and the harbor had taken her in the way it took in every such child: it gave her to the tide-house, where the dead were kept and

counted, and told her that it was an honor. It had turned out to be one. She had learned to read the Ledger by the age of ten. She had learned to write it by twelve. She had learned, somewhere in the intervening years, that a person who is good at keeping a record of loss will be trusted with almost anything except doing something about it.

She had been the clerk on the rope.

That was the thing no one else in the harbor ever said aloud and everyone knew. The day the lamp-men broke into the seam at the Weeping Stair, it had been Tamsin Orre they lowered, on a hemp line, thirty-one fathoms into the dark, because the Ledger required a clerk to be present at the opening of any gallery and she was the one on duty. She had gone down swinging in the cold with her little black book between her teeth. She had seen the honey-colored stone come out of the wall in the lantern light, whole, smooth, and warm to the touch, with the shape of a small curled body inside it. And she had put her palm against it, because she was a clerk and it was unrecorded, and felt it crack.

She had been the first thing the girl saw.

That was not in the Ledger either.

"They'll want the shrine," Ibb said.

He had caught her on the stair, at the turn of the second landing, where she stopped most mornings to get her breath. Clerk-Superior Ibb was seventy, bone-thin, with a face like a sail left out in rain and a voice that had read the dead into the Ledger for forty years without once cracking. He was not a bad man. She had loved him, as a child. He had taught her her letters.

"The shrine, Superior."

"The Honey Chapel, at the head of the cliff road. It was built for exactly this, Tamsin. The first founders cut it for the Sleepers. Three hundred years it has stood empty, and now we have one, awake, and she is being kept in a *house*." He said it as though the word were an obscenity. "The spring tide is eleven days off. The council is minded to agree. We hold the Naming, we give her a proper station, we put her in the chapel where the harbor may attend her."

"Attend her."

"With respect. With ceremony. As we do with everything that is holy."

"She's not holy, Superior. She's nine." She heard her own voice go thin and hard, and let it. "She's a child who hasn't eaten properly in three months and can't tell you why she's frightened. If you put her in a chapel with four hundred people singing, she will go to ground in the wall."

"You do not know that."

"I know that I carried the tray ninety-four days before he came." It came out louder than she meant. "I know that she screamed at a man who tried to be kind to her, and that no one has been in her room who wasn't afraid of her, or wanting something from her, or both. I know exactly what she needs. She needs nobody to do anything for a while."

Ibb looked at her, and for a moment she thought that he might simply say it, the thing he always said. *You are a junior clerk.* It stood ready on his face like a stamp.

He said, instead, very quietly: "That is what the stranger is doing."

"Yes."

"And it is working."

"It is the only thing that has." She swallowed. "I don't know why. I'd give a year of my life to know why."

"I do not like it," Ibb said, after a pause. "It has nothing in it I recognize. A man comes to a locked door and does not knock." He shook his head slowly. "But I have kept the Ledger forty years, and I have never seen it describe a thing that worked."

He went on up the stair. She stood with her back against the wall, shaking, and waited until she had stopped.

It was the strangest week of her life, and she wrote almost none of it down.

She had been prepared for the girl to remain a closed door. She had been prepared for the stranger to fail, and go home, and for the council to take it as proof. She had even, God forgive her, been prepared to be glad. She had made herself ready for that, in the dark, in the bed in the tide-house where she slept, with a resentment she had examined as honestly as she could: that a man from the great cities, with a famous name, could stroll into a room she had spent three months in, and be loved.

He had not strolled. He had burned his hand. He had sat on a bare floor for three days with a face like something carved, and she had stood in the doorway and watched, and had found it impossible to hate him.

What she could not forgive was that he made it look so simple.

The girl was out of the blankets now. That was the fact, and it stood in the middle of the room like a piece of furniture. On the sixth day she came out and sat, not near him, but in the same patch of window light, and put her palms on the sill and looked, for the first time, at the harbor. On the seventh she took a blanket from the nest and laid it over his knees while he slept. She did it with an expression of such stern, unexamined tenderness that Tamsin had to leave the room.

She had never done anything like that for Tamsin. She had never once taken the tray.

Of course not, Tamsin thought, on the stair, with her forehead against the cool whitewash. *You never stopped trying.*

It was a humbling thing to learn at twenty-two. She had spent three months being good. She had been patient, which she'd thought was the same as waiting. She had been gentle, and quiet, and reliable, and on time. She had brought the tray the same hour every day, set it in the same spot, withdrawn the same distance. She had been, she saw now, a perfect clerk. She had been the best record-keeper the harbor had ever trained. She had treated the girl as a thing to be tended and

entered, in good order, and the girl had understood that perfectly, and had known the whole time what she was to the harbor. She was an *entry.*

The stranger had not entered her. He had just sat down.

On the ninth night, Caelen fell asleep sitting up.

It was the first time. He had gone three days on bread and water and cat-naps and the hard cold patience he carried like a coal, and on the evening of the ninth his head went back against the wall, and stayed. Tamsin came up the stair at the end of the day to relieve him, as she had every night, and stopped in the doorway.

The girl was sitting in the middle of the floor, cross-legged, in the moonlight from the window, with her back to the nest and her eyes on the sleeping man. She was humming. It was very low and very faint. It was not the wandering thread of the first days. It was a slow, even, careful tone, held and held, as if she were keeping a lamp alight.

Tamsin did not move.

She stood in the door with the tray in her hands, as she had stood ninety-four times, and she thought of Ibb, and the shrine, and the spring tide eleven days off. She thought of the black book in her sash, and of every pencil line. She thought, *I could enter this.* She could write it down. *Day 103. Subject observed to hum while the visitor slept.* It would be accurate. It would be a record. It would be precisely the kind of thing that a harbor with no idea what to do would read, and file, and put in a box.

She put the book away.

It was an act of such small, enormous, appalling disloyalty that her hands shook. She stood very still. She did not write. She did not speak. She sat down, slowly, on the boards just inside the door, a good ten feet from the girl, with the tray at her knee, and folded her hands in her lap, and for the first time in ninety-four days she did nothing at all.

The hum went on. After a while, she found that she was humming too. Not well. Badly, flat, in the key of a lullaby she had not thought of since she was six, a low tuneless thing that came out of her throat before she knew it was there. She stopped, appalled.

The girl's head turned.

She looked at Tamsin across the moonlit floor, with the strange green-gold eyes, and for a long moment neither of them moved. Then the girl lifted one finger, very slightly, and moved her own note up a half-step. Tamsin stared. She moved hers. Up. The girl nodded, a tiny, severe, unmistakable nod, the nod of a teacher with a slow pupil. She moved hers again.

It took Tamsin a full minute to understand that she was being corrected.

She laughed. It escaped her in a startled little gasp, and the girl's face did something unfamiliar, a slight tightening at the corners of the mouth, and Tamsin thought, with a wild disbelief, *she's smiling.*

Then the girl stood up, and crossed the floor with her light quick steps, and stopped in front of her. She looked down at the tray, at the bread and the cooling egg and the bowl with its skin of cold milk. She looked at Tamsin.

She picked up the bread.

She did not take it away to the nest. She stood where she was, in the moonlight, and ate it, crumb by crumb, with her eyes on Tamsin's face, as if saying, in the only language she had: *there. Now you know.*

Tamsin sat very still and let her.

A hundred and three days, she thought. It wasn't a number the Ledger wanted. She didn't write it down.

Chapter Seven — Names for What She Is

The first word she learned was *stay*, and he had not meant to teach it.

It happened on the twelfth morning. He had gone down the stair at dawn to wash and eat something that was not bread, and when he came back up, the door was open and she was standing in the middle of the room with her arms stiff at her sides, rigid as a post, and the nest behind her torn half-apart. She had not cried. She had not made the sound. She had simply stood and waited, with the dreadful patience of a creature that expected to be left, and when he came in she looked at him and her whole body let go.

"I'm back," he said. He crossed the floor slowly and sat. "I'm here. I'll go and I'll come back. I'm not going. *Stay.*"

He had not planned the last word. It was simply the shortest one he had. She tilted her head, and her mouth moved, and a sound came out that was not quite a sound. It was a shape, a held breath with an edge on it. *Sthhay.*

He stared at her.

"Again," Tamsin said, from the door, in a whisper. "Say it again."

"Stay."

Sthhay. Her lips pulled back from her teeth as if the shape tasted odd. She did it a third time, and a fourth, and by the fifth it was nearly a word, thin and hoarse and breathy and entirely her own, and she had her hand pressed flat to the floor between them as if to hold it in place.

He looked away so she would not see his face.

It was how he had been taught, and he had forgotten that he remembered.

Varrick had not sat him down with a book. He had not drawn pictures or made lists. He had put an Aethel-Core in Caelen's palm and said, *this is marrow,* and let the weight of it do the work. He had named a thing while it was heavy in the hand. He had said *conduit* with the brass cold against his own wrist. He had never once said a word in the abstract. A word was something you held.

So Caelen taught her the same way, with his hands.

Bread came on the thirteenth day. He broke a heel of the harbor's good rye in two, and put half in her palm, and said it, and she said it, and tore it with her teeth. *Cold* was the window glass. He laid her hand against it in the early morning and held his own beside it, and she snatched hers away with a hiss, and then, slowly, put it back. *Hot* was the porridge bowl. He turned his burned palm over so that she could see the white scar across it, the curve of the rim, and pointed to his hand, and then to the bowl, and said it, and he saw her understand.

That was the hard one. She sat looking at his palm for a long time. Then she reached out and, very carefully, with one finger, touched the edge of the scar.

"I'm sorry," he said. He didn't know whether she would understand, and he said it anyway.

She said nothing. She stroked the scar once, from end to end, with the pad of her finger, as a person might stroke a sleeping animal. And she hummed. It was not the thin wandering thread of her first days. It was a short low note, almost a murmur, and he felt it in the burn like a cool hand laid on it. The skin did not heal. But the ache went out of it, and stayed out of it for the rest of the day.

He did not say anything about that to Tamsin.

It went like that for a week. He learned that she would take a new word best in the morning, when the room was warm and the tide was out, and that she hated being asked. She hated pointing games. She hated flat objects held up and named, and she hated the picture books, which she regarded with a stony contempt that Tamsin found hilarious. She would learn a thing only if it was

done. Open was a door. *Close* was the same door. *Wet* was the washing basin, a lesson that ended with all three of them soaked to the elbow. *Mine* he did not teach her. She taught herself, around the second week, by taking the wooden horse with the missing ear and carrying it everywhere with an air of such ferocious proprietorship that nobody dared to touch it.

Rook came on the sixteenth day. Caelen had asked him not to, and he came anyway, and sat on the top stair outside the door with his elbows on his knees and a paper twist of candied peel in his fist, and did not come in.

"She's looking at me," he said, in an undertone, after a quarter of an hour.

"She does that."

"Like I'm a loaf."

"She's never seen anyone with a face like yours."

"I have a great face." But he held out the peel, flat on his palm, on the threshold, and sat there with his hand out for twenty minutes without once complaining. At the end of it the girl crossed the floor, quick and light, and took one piece, and sniffed it, and ate it. Then she looked at Rook with unmistakable severity and said, "Bread."

"No," Rook said. "That's peel."

"Bread."

"It's *peel,* you little —" He stopped. His face did something unguarded, a crumpling, and he put the heel of his hand to his eyes. "Oh, hell. Hell, Caelen. She said it. She said a word to *me.*"

"I know."

"It's the wrong word."

"It's the right one," Caelen said, softly. "It means she wants more."

He taught her the cliff on the nineteenth day.

He had not meant to do it. It was a window-lesson, nothing more, a quiet morning with the harbor spread out below like a toy: the roofs, the green water, the tarred boats nodding at the foot of the wall. He had pointed to the fishermen and said *men,* and to the gulls and said *birds,* and she had repeated them with her new hard breathy care. Then she had leaned out over the sill, farther than he liked, and stopped.

The tide was out. The cliff stood bare to its root in the pale light, black rock streaked top to bottom with long honey-colored bands, glowing faintly where the sun came through them. She was looking at it with her whole body. Her breath had stopped. Her hand, on the sill, had gone white.

"That's stone," he said, gently. "*Stone.*"

She did not answer. She had gone entirely still, the way she had on the first day, with her eyes on his chest, except that now they were on the cliff. She stared at it for a very long time. Then she

turned her head and looked at him, and he saw in her face something he had no word for in any language, a dawning, terrible, unclouded comprehension, as of a child who has just seen, for the first time, the shape of the thing she came out of.

He crouched beside her.

"That's what held you," he said. He kept his voice low. "That's what you were in. You, and me. We were in the stone. Do you understand? Me. *Me.*" He put his palm flat against his own sternum. "Caelen. Caelen."

She watched his hand. She put her own palm on her chest, a smaller copy of the gesture, and made a face, a small, helpless, furious grimace of someone who has just found out that the world has a missing piece.

"You don't have one," he said. "Yet. That's all right. I had one. I kept it. I held onto it in the dark, all by myself, because it was the only thing that was mine." The words came out of him slowly, one at a time, each one costing him something. He was not sure he was speaking to her anymore. "It was a stone. It was small and warm. I carried it for ten years. I'm telling you, because I think somebody should have told me it was allowed to be yours."

The room was very quiet. The tide began to turn under the house.

She put out a hand. She laid her palm on his chest, over the coal, and he did not flinch. She pressed. Her eyes closed. And she hummed, a long, slow, searching sound that went down into him as the sea had gone down under the *Patience,* through the planking and the bone.

It was not the note she had been giving him for days. It had a shape in it. It rose, and bent, and rose again, and he felt it close around something in his breast that had no name. A word. He knew it was a word. It was not a word he knew. It was not from the harbor tongue, or the Spire's, or the Wastes'. It was older than any of them, and it had come up out of somewhere beneath language, like the first breath of a body that has been under water a long time.

He did not know what it meant. But he felt what it did. It was a hand at the back of his neck. It was a door left open. It was the voice of a thing that had been alone in the dark and was no longer.

When she opened her eyes, they were wet.

He told Seraphina that night, in the guest house, over a cold supper neither of them wanted.

She listened with her whole face. When he had finished she took a stub of pencil from her coat and a sheet of paper, and asked him to hum it. He tried. It came out wrong; it would not hold in his mouth. She asked him again, and again, until she had a rough scrawl of curves on the page, like the track of a bird in sand.

"I don't know it," she said, at last. "I've read every Lithoi fragment the reliquary held, and several that it didn't. I have never seen a sound like this written down." She turned the page toward the lamp. "But I think it is tonal, Caelen. Not music. A word that depends on pitch the way ours depends on vowels. Which means that it has a grammar. Which means that she has a language."

“She said she didn’t.”

“Vesh said she didn’t. He was wrong.” Seraphina’s eyes were very bright. “She never lacked words. She lacked anyone who could hear them.”

He looked at the paper. He had spent ten years of his life believing he was alone in the dark. He had been a fool, and it did not matter. He could feel her, even now, in the white house above the harbor, humming his note back to the sleeping town, and for the first time he thought that perhaps the question his life had been asking was not *what am I.* It was *who else.*

Chapter Eight — The Cliff Road

It was Malakar who noticed the lamps.

They had left the town at first light, the three of them, by a path that began behind the tide-house and climbed north along the clifftop, and Caelen had gone with them only because the girl had told him to. She had told him in her way, with a small severe push at his shoulder and a word she had been practicing for three days. *Go.* And then, very faint, with a look of fierce effort: *Back.*

“Back,” he had said. “I’ll come back.”

Tamsin had stood in the doorway with the wooden horse in one hand and said, “I’ll stay. You have my word.” It was the first time he had left the room in nineteen days. He had walked down the stair with his hands feeling too empty, and Rook had taken one look at his face, said, “You look like a man leaving his dog at the vet,” and linked an arm through his without another word.

The cliff road was good. That was what he noticed first. It was packed shell and gravel, edged with white stones, drained by little stone gutters every twenty paces, and swept. Someone swept it. In a harbor where nothing was wasted, where the nets were mended till they were mostly

mending and the boats were tarred till they were mostly tar, someone had taken the trouble, for what looked like generations, to keep a footpath along the top of a cliff clean enough to walk barefoot.

"Who uses it?" he asked.

"Nobody," said Malakar, who had been counting under his breath for a quarter of an hour. "That's the difficulty."

He stopped and pointed down.

They were small. That was the reason it had taken so long to see them. Set into the face of the cliff at irregular intervals, just below the lip, each in a niche of its own cut into the black rock, were little iron lamps. They were no larger than a man's two fists. They had glass fronts and tin hoods against the weather, and each one was lit. In the broad morning light the flames were almost invisible: a faint steady yellow, not wavering in the wind.

"There's one every —" Rook leaned out carefully, one hand on the wall. "Hell, there's *hundreds*."

"Forty-one," said Malakar. "I have been counting since the headland. They are not evenly spaced. They cluster. There are six in the first half-mile and then none for three-quarters of a mile and then eleven, very close, in the dip beyond the old signal-post." He rubbed his jaw. "And they are all lit. At the third hour of the morning, with no one on the road. Somebody comes every night and trims them, and somebody comes every morning to check."

"A lighthouse?"

"A lighthouse points outward. These point in." He shook his head slowly. "I spent twenty years learning to read what a building is for from where the doors are. A person who lights a lamp facing the rock is not signalling to anyone. They are keeping something company."

Caelen looked down at the nearest. It was set into the cliff a body's length beneath his feet, an iron hood, a yellow flame, and behind and beneath it, a long vertical band of honey-colored stone, glowing very faintly in the sun.

He lay down on his stomach on the gravel, and put his palm flat on the edge, and leaned.

The cliff sang.

He had expected the pulse. He had been feeling it for nineteen days, in the town, in the harbor, in the long swell of the tide in the foundations of the house. But he had not been standing at the edge of it. Lying there with his arm over the drop and his cheek against the gravel, he felt the entire face of the headland as a single living thing. It was warm. It was slow. It was a thousand heartbeats at once, all very faint, all just slightly out of step with each other, like a field of grass moving in a wind. And beneath the beat, in his chest, came the thin high note of something else, something he had learned to know in a whitewashed room.

They were *humming.*

Not aloud. Not for any ear but his. A low continuous murmur, from every lamp, from every niche, from every band of honey stone along three miles of cliff, rising and falling together with the tide. He knew it. He had heard it in the dark under a mountain, in the first minute of his life. It was the sound a body makes when it is held.

"Caelen," Rook said. "Caelen. Your hands."

He looked. They had lengthened. Not much, a half-inch, the nails dull and thick. He could not feel it. He was crying, and it took him a moment to understand that, too.

"They're asleep," he said, in a voice that did not sound like his. "They're all — down there. There's one right below me, I can feel her. She's small. She's curled up. She's *dreaming*." He pressed his palm harder against the rock. "There are people in the cliff, Rook."

Neither of them answered. Malakar had gone grey. Rook put one hand on Caelen's back, quite lightly, the way a person lays a hand on a horse that has begun to shake, and kept it there.

They found the first of the keepers a mile on.

She was sitting on an upturned crate in the lee of a drystone wall, an old woman with a face like folded leather and white hair cut straight across at the jaw, mending a net. She did not look up when they came along the road. She had a bone needle in her fingers, and a small tin oil-can at her feet, and a ring of keys at her belt, and she waited for the shuttle to pass through the mesh before she said, in a perfectly level voice:

"You've seen, then."

"We've seen," said Malakar.

"Good." She tied off the knot. "I'd rather you saw it from the road than found it by accident. We've had accidents." She lifted her eyes. They were pale and shrewd and not in the least afraid. "I'm Nessa. This is my stretch, from the signal-post to the dip. My mother had it before me, and hers before that. I trim twenty-two lamps. I've never missed a night."

"Twenty-two," Caelen said.

"There's sixteen sleepers in my stretch, give or take. They don't all have a lamp. The big pockets have two." She said it as another woman might have said she kept hens. "We call ourselves the lamp families. There's nine. It's not a thing we say in the town."

"Why do you do it?"

She looked at him for a long time, and her face changed.

"So they're not in the dark," Nessa said.

It was so simple that nobody spoke.

"I know it's foolish," she said at last. "They can't see a lamp through two fathom of stone. My mother told me that. But she told me that her mother said, and hers before, that you don't leave a sleeper in the dark. You give them a light, and you sit by them, and you tell them the tide. It's a

promise, you see. Nobody wrote it down. The first founders made it, when they found the first of them, and said, *we'll not wake what we can't keep.* So we keep. We light the lamps. And we wait for the world to be ready." She looked down at her net. "It's been three hundred years. I don't think the world is ready. I think it's just very big, and very late."

The Brine-Reeve found them at dusk on the way back.

He came along the cliff road alone, on foot, in the salt-stiffened coat, and stopped a few paces off with the lamps coming on behind him one by one in the blue air. He did not look surprised. He looked, Caelen thought, like a man who has watched a house burn for a long time and now sees the roof go in.

"Nessa told me," Hask said. "She sent a boy."

"We weren't hiding it."

"I know you weren't. You walked along the open road. I should have posted a man." He paused. "I did not, because I thought: if they find it, they find it. Better by their own eyes than by a clerk's mouth." A heavy breath. "You understand why there is a lock on your door."

"Forty-one," Malakar said. "How many are there?"

"Sleepers? A hundred and nine, by the Ledger." Hask turned and looked down the long gravel road, shining faintly now in the last light, with its little yellow lamps burning in the dusk like a string of sparks. "I know the number because I have been Reeve twenty-six years and my father was Reeve before me and he told me, in his bed, on the last night. He said, *Hask. We are not the owners of this. We are the keepers of the door.* I did not understand him." He rubbed his face with one broad hand. "I think I do now."

"The Guild's been here," said Malakar.

It was not a question. Hask's head came up sharply.

"The stakes," Malakar said. He pointed up the cliff, at the clifftop above the nearest lamp, where Caelen now saw them: a row of short grey-painted posts driven into the turf at regular intervals, each topped with a little tin flag. "Those were not here in the spring. The paint is fresh. The holes have not weathered. Somebody has surveyed the length of this cliff, from the headland to the signal-post, in the last six months, and has taken some care to look like a fishery inspection."

"A Guild vessel anchored in the roads at the thaw," Hask said slowly. "Four men ashore, with brass instruments. We took them for the Salt Office. They said they were measuring the strand for a tariff." He stopped. "They were very polite."

"They always are," Malakar said.

Hask looked at the posts. Caelen watched his broad weathered face as the understanding went through it. Twenty-six years, his father's last words, the lamps, the swept road; and an afternoon, in the spring, when four polite men had walked the clifftop with their theodolites and gone home.

"They counted them," he said.

"Yes."

"They *counted*." His voice cracked, and he got it back. "They have been in my harbor and counted my dead."

"They're not dead," Caelen said.

Hask turned to him, and for the first time looked him squarely in the face.

"No," he said, very quietly. "I know. That is the whole trouble."

Vesh unrolled the chart on the tide-house table that night, by lamplight, with Seraphina at his shoulder and Tamsin in the doorway. It was a cliff-section, drawn in ink on oiled linen, in a hand nearly three centuries old, with a tiny cross at every pocket. He did not need to be asked. He ran a finger down the length of it, silently, and laid beside it the oldest volume of the Ledger, open at the first page, with its black marks standing in the margin like a row of little fence-posts.

Seraphina counted them. It took a long time. She did it twice. When she had finished, she said the number aloud, in a voice so quiet that the tide almost covered it.

"A hundred and nine."

"Yes," said Vesh.

"The marks are the sleepers."

"Yes." He took off his spectacles, and wiped them, and did not put them back on. "I have counted everything in this harbor but them. I think I was afraid I would find that I had been keeping a nursery." He looked at Caelen. "I have been the Keeper of the Deep Ledger for nineteen years. I believed I was keeping the dead."

Chapter Nine — The Names

A note on point of view: this chapter departs from Caelen's perspective, following Chairman Reth. See style-guide.md §4.

RETH

He did his sums at sea, as he did them everywhere, and by the twentieth day the number had stopped changing.

The Guild ship was called the *Tally*. It was a long grey three-master with no figurehead and no brass, built for survey work and cargo and the quiet movement of men with instruments, and it sailed with a steadiness that Reth found, as he found most of the Guild's works, both admirable and faintly oppressive. It had a cabin for the Chairman. He had asked for a smaller one, and been refused, and had made the best of it. He sat at the narrow table with the lamp swinging and his leather ledgers laid out before him, the public one and the private one, and let the pen go down the columns.

Spring tally. Failures, confirmed.

A camp at Dunmere, east of the Wastes, fraudulent: a man who charged four families a season's wages each for a working he had copied from a broadside and could not perform. Two drifted past reach. One died.

A practitioner at Long Reach, honest, untrained, who attempted the full rite on a Shifter in the last hour of drift and held the anchor wrong. The Shifter bit through his own tongue. The practitioner has not spoken since.

A child, nine, in a barn at Greyfen, South Quarter. Mother licensed under the finding as a house-of-treatment keeper. Mother absent two nights. Child's drifting brother, fourteen, Shifted in the straw. The mother returned to find them both. The straw was still warm.

He had sat with that last one for some time. He had gone to Greyfen himself, in April, on a mule, and stood in the barn in the damp and the quiet, and put his palm against the post where the boy had been chained by a well-meaning neighbor. Then he had gone home and written the entry in his small clear hand, in the plain black ink he used for all of them, and under *Disposition* had put the word *Unattended.*

It was the word that mattered. He had put it in the Chairman's book, in the public ledger, in the hearing's minutes. It was not a word he had invented. It was the word he had spent forty years learning to see, and it was the word the hall's finding, with all its goodness, had not made go away.

He did not think of himself as a man who was glad when the world proved him right. But he knew precisely how many pages he had left to fill.

He was not going to the Salt Coast for the child.

He wished to be exact with himself about that. His clerk, Tam, who was young and kind and had read the broadsides, had asked him on the second day, with the hesitancy of someone who expects to be wrong: *the girl, sir. You are going to see the girl?* And Reth had said, *I am going to see the harbor.* It was true. It was also the sort of true thing that, when he said it, made him feel as if he had rubbed a coin between his fingers and found the worn place.

He had learned about the girl as the whole territory had, from a broadside. He had learned about the harbor months earlier, from a report.

The report had come to his desk in the Spire on a grey morning in March, in the ordinary packet of survey returns that arrived from the coastal parties, bound in the Guild's plain grey card. It had been a dull report. He had nearly set it aside. It concerned a four-man party's reconnaissance of the Salt Coast cliffs, on the third harbor's headland, for the Board's long-range inventory. It listed positions, bearings, magnetic anomalies. Under *Findings* was a short note in a surveyor's cramped hand:

Forty-one discrete seams of an unusual character along the headland, within a three-mile span. Resonance readings consistent with intact marrow-glass of high grade. Anomalous: each seam exhibits a steady low-frequency periodic pulse, not matching tide or any known source. Recommend detailed survey under Charter 9, with test charges.

He had read it three times. He had gone cold in his chair.

Reth was a Guild man. He had been a Guild man for forty-four years. He knew what *test charges* meant, and he knew what a periodic pulse was, because he had seen a periodic pulse once, in a mess hall at Hollow Cut, in the hands of a boy named Deshane. He knew what happened to a thing that was warm and slow and alive when a charge of black powder was set against its wall.

He had stopped the survey. He had done it that same afternoon, by a letter in his own hand, under his own seal, to the Board's clerk of works. *Charter 9 test charges on the Salt Coast headland are suspended pending my review.* It had felt like a small thing. A suspension. A pause.

The letter had gone out in March. The *Tally* had sailed in June. And in the last week of May, a courier in the Spire had brought him a second packet, from the same four-man party, from the same grey office, with a note in the clerk of works' tidy hand.

Suspension received. Be advised that the party's sealed orders under Charter 9, dated the fourth of February, antedate the Chairman's letter and, per Board practice, may not be countermanded except by the full Board in session. The Engineer-Captain has been informed.

He understood the Board. That was the infuriating thing. He had given forty years to it and he knew it to the bone: the patient accretion of authority, the way it layered permission upon permission until no single voice could stop the thing that a hundred voices had once agreed to start. He had come to the Spire and built the first public register in the territory's history. He had shaken it to its foundations for ten days in the Hall of Canon. And he had gone home to learn that the machine was too old for even the Chairman to turn off.

He had one hand free. He had the *Tally,* a hall letter, a ship's worth of authority, and three weeks' sailing time behind a party of strangers who had gone out ahead of him on a hall vessel with Maren's seal. He did not hate them. He wanted to be clear about that, in his small cabin, with the lamp swinging. He had not hated the strata boy, who was a man now. He did not hate the archivist or the Inquisitor or the young noble with the mended cuff. He thought they were very brave and very probably wrong, and he had never in his life been so afraid of being right.

Forty-one seams. A hundred and nine, if the surveyor's pulse count is accurate. He had done the arithmetic, in the hall, in the spring, in this cabin. It was not complicated. A waking by blast killed. The archive was quite clear on it. Seven in three hundred years, and every one of them dead in weeks. There was nothing else in the whole sorry record to set against it, and a man did not need to be a mathematician to know that a test charge set in the headland of the third harbor would not leave one body alone.

That was the figure that had brought him to sea. A hundred and nine. He kept it in his head like a splinter.

Engineer-Captain Halse came to the cabin on the twenty-first night, as expected, to ask for the order.

He was a square, well-fed, careful man of forty with sandy whiskers and an expression of patient reasonableness, and he stood in the doorway with his cap in his hands and said, "Chairman. I wondered if you had reconsidered."

"The survey will wait, Captain."

"With respect, sir. The orders are the Board's. I hold them under seal. They were issued in February, before your suspension. I have a duty to the charter." He said it gently. "The weather

is turning. We have a short season. If we do not begin the test shots in the next fortnight, the autumn gales will close the roads, and the work will be delayed a year."

"A year would do no harm."

"A year is a long time, sir, in a survey of this character." Halse turned his cap round once. "If I may say. I have read the surveyors' reports. I do not think we know what we have found. It may be the greatest reserve in the territory. It may be a hazard. It would be irresponsible to leave it uncharted."

Reth looked at him. He could see, as clearly as he had ever seen anything, the good man in front of him: orderly, conscientious, and quite sincere. Halse did not want to kill anyone. He wanted to *know.* He had the Guild's own deep conviction, which Reth shared and had shared all his life, that an unmapped thing was a danger and a mapped one was safe.

That is the trouble, Reth thought. *There is no villain in this. There is only a very large, very reasonable machine.*

"You will not fire," he said, "a single charge without my written order. Not a test shot. Not a sounding. Do you understand?"

"I understand the instruction, sir."

"That is not what I asked."

A pause. Halse's face did not change. "I have heard it, Chairman," he said, evenly. "I will convey it to the party."

It was, Reth knew, a refusal. It was the politest he had ever received.

He sat for a long time after the Captain had gone.

Then he drew the private ledger toward him, the small one with the cracked spine that he kept, even at sea, in the lining of his coat, and opened it to the last page. There was the column on the right, headed in his small young careful hand, and in it a short list of names.

Roshe. Lisbet of Vael. A boy called Ned, at Long Reach, who had drifted and been treated by a woman who knew the rite and was never licensed and had saved him anyway. Three names. In forty years, three. He looked at them for a long moment, and thought of a hundred and nine, and of the nine pages of the old Ledger that he had never seen and could picture perfectly.

He wrote the date. He wrote, beneath it, *The Salt Coast. Third harbor.* He did not write a number. He left the space.

In the first grey light of morning, the lookout cried the headland. Reth rose and went on deck in his plain coat, with the leather book in his hand, and stood at the rail. The coast came up out of the sea as a long black wall, banded with honey. He could see the white houses climbing it like a held breath, and, faint along the clifftop, in the dawn, a row of tiny yellow lights.

He stood there until the lights went out one by one as the sun reached them.

Please, he thought, to nobody. It was the first prayer he had made in forty years, and he did not finish it.

Chapter Ten — The Name She Chose

They came for her at dawn on the morning of the second spring tide, and they came with a bell.

Caelen heard it from the guest house before he was fully awake: a clear cold chime, struck slowly, once for every step of the stair. It was the tide-bell, the one the harbor rang for the drowned. He was on his feet and dressed before the third stroke, and when he reached the white house at the head of the fourth flight, the procession was already waiting outside the door.

There were twelve of them in the blue sashes of the tide-house, in two ranks with a gap between, and at their head, thin and upright in the grey light, stood Clerk-Superior Ibb. He held a small iron hand-bell in front of him like a candle. Behind the clerks, at a courteous distance, stood the council, and behind the council, filling the stair and the roofs and the narrow lanes and clinging to the cliff like barnacles, stood what looked to Caelen like the entire town.

“This is the second tide,” Ibb said. He did not raise his voice. “The Naming was deferred once, by the Reeve’s ruling, to give the stranger time. The time has been given.” He bowed, slightly, to Caelen, with real courtesy and no apology. “I would not do this at the door. But the chapel is cold, and the tide will not wait.”

“She doesn’t want to go,” said Tamsin.

She stood in the doorway of the white house with her back to the room and her hands wrapped in her sash, small and furious and shaking. She had not slept. She had a smear of ink on her cheek.

“She is nine years old, Tamsin Orre. She does not know what she wants.”

"She knows exactly what she wants." Her voice cracked. "She wants everyone to stop wanting things from her."

Caelen looked past them at the crowd. He saw Hask in the front rank, grim and still, with a face like an old stone. He saw Vesh, in the blue coat with the tally buttons, white to the lips. He saw Seraphina, Malakar, and Corwin, standing together on the third landing; and Rook, who had pushed through to the door and stood at Caelen's shoulder, saying nothing, with one hand loose at his side and the other resting on the hilt of a knife he had promised not to draw.

He did not know what to do. That was the plain truth of it. He had walked out of a mine, and a forest, and a burning lane, and he had never in his life been asked to stand between a child and a whole town that loved her.

Don't decide for her, he thought. *That's the only thing you know.*

He turned round.

She was sitting up in the middle of the floor with the wooden horse in her lap, wide awake, in the grey smock, with her short hair standing up on one side. She had heard the bell. He could see that. She had heard every stroke of it, and she was holding herself with a stillness he knew, the stillness of an animal that has already decided what it will do if it cannot get away.

He crossed the floor and sat down in front of her. He didn't say anything for a while.

"They want to take you somewhere," he said, finally. He chose the words with great care. He used the ones she had. "Big house. Many people. They want to give you a name."

Name. She mouthed it, soundlessly. Her eyes moved to his chest and then, slowly, up to his face.

"I don't want you to go," he said. "I want you to stay. But I don't —" He stopped. He took a breath. "It's yours. It isn't mine to say. If you go, I'll come. If you stay, I'll stay. If you want to run, I'll —" He couldn't finish that one. "Whatever you choose. It's yours."

She looked at him for a very long time.

Then she stood up, put the wooden horse down carefully on the quilt, and walked past him and out onto the threshold of the white house, where the clerks and the council and the whole silent harbor could see her.

It was so quiet that he could hear the gulls.

She stood there in her cut-down smock in the first level light, so small against the great pale cliff that she looked like a mark made by a pencil. The tide was at its height. Below the stair the green water slapped at the foot of the wall. A thousand faces were turned up to her, and none of them made a sound.

She looked at them. She looked, with great deliberation, from one face to the next, as though counting. Ibb with his bell. Hask with his heavy stone face. Vesh, holding himself together by the buttons of his coat. Her eyes rested on each one for a moment, and moved on.

Then she looked at the cliff.

He felt her do it. He felt it in his own chest, a sudden drop in the air, as though the whole town had breathed out. She tilted her head back, and the green-gold light came into her eyes from the stone. And she opened her mouth, and sang.

It was a single note.

It was not loud. It was low, and clear, and absolutely pure, and it began somewhere at the bottom of her chest and rose. It rose through the white house and the stair and the roofs, through the iron lamps in their little niches, and out over the water. It did not waver. It held, perfectly level, for a breath, and then two, and then it bent. It turned over on itself, once, like a wave, and climbed. It rang out against the face of the cliff, and the cliff answered.

He heard it come back. He heard all of it. The honey-banded stone along three miles of headland took up the note and gave it back to her, a thousand voices, a hundred and nine, deep and soft and slow. Every lamp along the cliff road flared at once, a long bright ripple of gold like the lighting of a string. In the street below, a dog began to howl and was silenced. A fishwife dropped her basket. On the third landing, Corwin made a small broken sound and put both hands over his face.

She held the note until she had no breath left. Then she let it fall, and the cliff held it a moment longer, and let it go.

In the silence afterward, she turned and looked at him. Her face was wet. She was not smiling. She was entirely, solemnly sure.

That, her eyes said. *That's the one.*

"Did you hear it?" Tamsin said.

She was whispering. She had come across the floor in a kind of daze and stood at his elbow with her black book out and the pencil in her trembling hand. "Did you hear it? Caelen? It — I can't —" She had gone white. She stared at the open page as if it might bite her. "How do I write that?"

"I don't know."

"It's got no letters. It's — she's —" She turned and looked at the girl, who was standing on the threshold with her hands at her sides and her head up, wholly composed, a small figure in grey with the whole cliff behind her. "That's her *name.* Isn't it? That's her own."

"Yes."

"The Ledger needs a word."

"Does it?"

Tamsin opened her mouth. She closed it. She looked at the pencil. And then, with great slowness, she turned back to the page, and set the point to the paper, and drew.

It took her four tries. She drew a curve, long and low, that climbed in the middle, and bent over, and rose to a final soft peak. Beside it she wrote the interval in the neat small tide-clerk's hand she'd been trained to, the pitch and the time, as though she were recording a bell. She looked at it for a long time. Then she tore the page out, carefully, along its stitching, and carried it down the stair, through the silent crowd, to the tide-house.

Vesh was waiting at the lectern.

He had not moved from the front rank. He had walked down ahead of her without a word, and was standing in the long room with his spectacles in his hand, and the great Ledger lay open under the window. It was open at the back. It was open at the page with the blank line.

Tamsin laid the torn sheet beside it. She smoothed it flat with the heel of her hand. For a moment nobody breathed.

"I will not write it," Vesh said. His voice was unsteady. "I cannot. It is not my place."

"It's not a theft," said Tamsin.

"No." He looked at her. He looked at the curve she had drawn: the little rising line, so small on the white paper, and the numbers beside it. His mouth worked. "No. I do not think that it is."

"The Ledger records what it is told."

"Yes." A shaky breath. "It does." And he took up the pen. It was a plain steel pen, the one he had used for nineteen years, and he dipped it, and wrote on the blank line under *Name,* in his neat, exact, shaking hand, the shape of a note. Not the letters. The curve. He drew it as Tamsin had drawn it, long and low and rising, and when it was finished, he put the pen down, and took off his coat, and laid it on the lectern, as a man lays down a coat on the quay of a harbor he has been standing guard on for years.

"There," he said. "She is entered."

Caelen stood at the window of the tide-house afterward and watched the harbor fill again with ordinary sound.

The crowd was breaking up. Ibb had gone back up the stair with his bell, very slowly, an old man, with a clerk on either arm. The council was talking in low urgent voices, and Hask stood apart, at the head of the quay, with his arms folded, looking at the cliff. The lamps had gone back to their small gold. Nessa was out on the road, a tiny dark figure with an oil-can, trimming wicks.

He had done it. He understood that with a kind of numb, shy astonishment. He had given a child the one thing that a man had given him once, in a rusting shelter, with a fire between them. Not a name. A name was not a thing you gave. The thing was the right to have one. Varrick had never said it. He had said *terms,* and *arithmetic,* and *it's not charity,* for nine years, because he had not had the words. But he had done it every day. He had walked down a ridge and not looked back.

You were never a debt, Caelen thought. *You were never anything but this.*

He put his hand flat on the glass.

She had come to stand beside him. He had not heard her. She stood with her chin barely over the sill, in the grey smock, and he looked down into her face and saw that it had changed. It was open. She was looking at the sea.

“Stay,” she said, in her small hoarse voice.

“Yes.”

“Caelen.” It came out wrong. It had too many breaths in it. “Caelen. *Stay.*”

He could not speak. He nodded.

Far out beyond the headland, in the clear morning, at the edge of the world where the green went into grey, a sail stood up out of the sea. It was a long low shape, three-masted, with no figurehead, and it was flying a pennant that he did not need to see closely. It was the colour of ash.

The girl did not look at it. She was looking at him.

Chapter One — The Grey Sail

The harbor had never needed walls, and by noon it had found out how to build them.

It began with the chain. There was a boom across the mouth of the third harbor, an iron chain as thick as a man’s thigh, laid on the bottom since before the oldest volume of the Ledger and raised only for storms. Hask gave the order from the quay without looking round, and a dozen men leaned on a capstan older than anyone’s grandfather. The chain came up out of the green water in long dripping links and stretched taut between the headland and the breakwater, black and wet,

with weed trailing from it. The *Tally* hove to a cable's length outside and let go her anchor with a sound like a door closing.

After that, nobody needed to give any more orders.

The women went home. They went quickly and without speaking, gathering their children against their skirts, and the doors of the lower town closed one by one down the length of the quay. The men stayed. They came out of the net-lofts and the boat-sheds and the fish-houses with whatever they had in their hands, boathooks, gaff poles, a whale-lance with a rusted blade, and stood along the stone edge of the harbor in a loose silent line, facing the sea. Nobody raised a weapon. They held them the way they held their nets, low and ready, and watched a grey ship ride at anchor in the sun.

"I've never seen a town hold its breath with a harpoon," Rook said.

"They've had practice," said Caelen.

He stood at the head of the third flight with the others, looking down. The girl was behind him in the white house, with Tamsin, with the door barred and the shutters closed and a bowl of cherries between them. She had heard the chain. She had made a sound when she heard it, a low rough hum with a rasp on the end, and then she had gone to the window and put both palms flat on the sill and said *no,* very clearly, to nobody.

He had not been able to tell her it would be all right. He had stopped telling her things he did not know.

A skiff put out from the *Tally* at the turn of the tide.

It carried two men. One rowed, a sailor in a grey jersey with his eyes on the oars. The other sat in the stern, very upright, in a plain grey coat, with a flat leather satchel across his knees. He did not wave or hold up a flag. He sat with his hands on the satchel and looked at the cliff, and the little boat came across the green water, slowly, toward the boom, and stopped.

"He wants to come through," Malakar said.

"Let him wait," said Hask.

The Reeve had come down to the quay-head and stood at the edge of the stone with his arms folded and the wind in his coat. He did not shout. He did not need to. The sound of his deep slow voice carried across the water as though he had spoken into a room. "Who are you, and what do you carry?"

"Reth, of the Guild's Board." The reply came back thin and clear. "Chairman, for what it is worth. I carry nothing but a satchel and a clerk, who is not in this boat. I have no instruments. I ask the harbor's leave to land, and the council's leave to speak, and I will go back to the ship afterward whatever is decided. I will not ask for the girl. I will not ask for the lamps. I have come to read you a list."

There was a long pause.

"A list," said Hask.

"Forty-one names. I think the council should hear them."

Nobody moved. Along the quay the line of men stood still as posts, with the lances in their hands. Caelen saw Hask's shoulders rise, and fall.

"Lower the chain," the Reeve said, at last, to nobody. "A fathom. No more."

They gave him the council hall, because there was nowhere else big enough, and then locked the doors behind him.

It was a long bare room at the top of the second stair, with a plank floor, a table of black oak, and eleven chairs in a horseshoe, much smaller than the Hall of Canon in the Spire and, to Caelen's eye, a good deal more frightening. The windows were shuttered. There were lamps. The council sat in the horseshoe in their salt-stiff coats, and Hask in the middle, and behind them, standing, in a double row against the wall, were the keepers of the lamps. Caelen counted nine. Nessa stood at the end with her net-needle in her hand. She had not put it down.

Reth stood at the end of the table with the satchel closed in front of him.

He looked smaller than Caelen remembered, and older, and more tired. He had lost weight. There were grey hollows under his eyes. But he held himself exactly as he had held himself at the lectern in the Hall of Canon, upright and plain, hands lightly folded, and when he spoke, it was in the same quiet dry voice that had read a thousand deaths into a public record without a flicker.

"I should say first," he said, "that I have no right to be here. I have no sanction from the Board. I was sent to review a survey and have exceeded my authority by the width of an ocean. If you would like to arrest me, I am told you have a very good lock."

A faint ripple of sound went through the room. It might have been a laugh. It died almost at once.

"I came to read you a list," Reth said. "I will read it, and then I will answer any question the council wishes to put. I ask you only to hear it to the end."

He opened the satchel and took out a single folded sheet. He did not look at it. He put it on the table, smoothed it flat, and said, in a perfectly level voice:

"The Weeping Stair."

It took him eleven minutes.

He read them one at a time, with the same weight on each, neither slowly nor quickly: the *Weeping Stair, the Heron's Knee, Nessa's Dip, the Drowned Bell, the Long Shelf, the Cradle Hole, the Pilot's Ear.* They were not the Guild's designations. They were not seam numbers. They were the names the harbor had given them over three hundred years, the names the lamp families used among themselves, the names that were written in no book but the oldest margin and on no map but the one the fishermen carried in their heads. He had gathered them somehow, in the spring, from the boatmen and the net-wives, from a polite man with a brass instrument asking where each place

was. And he read them in the order that they lay along the cliff, from the headland to the signal-post, with the faint, careful reverence of a man calling a roll.

"The Mother's Step. The Salt Door. The Little Chapel. The Lantern Shelf."

At the fourteenth name, Nessa made a small noise in her throat. At the twenty-second, she put her net-needle down.

"Thirty-eight. Thirty-nine. The Last Light. Forty."

He stopped. The room had gone absolutely silent. The lamp on the table burned straight up, without a flicker.

"Forty-one," Reth said. "The Old Mouth."

He folded his hands.

"They are not the names of the dead," he said. "I want to be exact about that. I have read a great many lists of the dead in my life. This is not one of them. These are the names of places where something is alive. A hundred and nine, if the old Ledger is correct. I think it is. Each one of these is a decision."

"A decision," said Hask. His voice was rough.

"Yes." Reth did not look away. "Somebody will have to decide what is done with each. Leave it, or open it. Light it, or wake it. Defend it, or yield it. I have been in this work forty years, Reeve, and I do not know of a thing in the whole territory that has been so long put off. Your people have decided, three hundred times, in the dark, by lamplight, that the answer was *not yet.* I am told it was a good answer. I would like to say that I honor it." A very faint breath. "But I did not come to honor it. I came because the Guild put a ship in your roads in the spring, and I was not there to stop it, and the survey it left behind has written *test charges* beside every name on this list."

Nobody spoke for a long time.

It was Hask who moved first. He stood up slowly from the middle of the horseshoe, a big heavy man in a salt-stiff coat, and walked round the end of the table until he stood face to face with Reth. He was a head taller. He looked down at the small plain man for a very long moment.

"You said you carried nothing," he said. "You carry forty-one names."

"I do."

"Where did you get them?"

"From your boatmen." Reth held his gaze. "A man named Dacey, at the fish-wharf, told the surveyor where the Pilot's Ear was and thought nothing of it. A woman called Brann gave him the Salt Door in return for a cup of tea. They were not betraying you. They were being polite to a stranger. It is the thing I fear most in the world, Reeve. That the harm will come to this harbor entirely by way of people being polite."

Hask stood very still.

“Do you want something?” he said, finally. “I ask plainly. I am too old to dance.”

“I want the harbor to hold the Guild’s engineer to its own law,” Reth said. “He carries sealed orders from the full Board. I cannot countermand them. You can. No instrument, no charge, no tool of the Guild is to be landed on this coast without the Reeve’s leave.” He paused. “I ask you to refuse him. I ask you to refuse *me.* I have no power on this headland but the one you choose to give. I would sooner you gave it to the Ledger than the Board.”

It was, Caelen thought, watching from the back of the hall, the most dangerous sentence he had ever heard a man say. It was an honest offer of surrender. And he did not for one moment believe that it was all of what Reth meant.

“Why?” Hask said.

Reth looked at him. And for an instant, Caelen saw it, the raw tired thing behind the dry composure, the same look he had worn in the Hall of Canon when a stranger took a Warden’s hands.

“Because it is the only way I know,” Reth said, “to keep a hundred and nine children from being counted by a man who means them no harm.”

Chapter Two — What Hask Fears

They locked Reth in the tide-house guest room, in the end, and it was the worst thing they could have done.

It was meant as a courtesy. The Reeve had said as much to the council with his hand on the black oak table: *The man put himself in our hands. We will not put him in the cells.* So Reth was given a room at the end of the long upper corridor, with a bed and a basin and a window overlooking the quay, and a clerk’s stool outside the door, and a boy of fourteen with a boathook to sit on it.

He thanked them. He asked for a pen. He sat at the window with his satchel and his small leather book and wrote, in a clear unhurried hand, for the rest of the afternoon, and every person in the harbor who passed beneath the window looked up at him, and looked away.

"It's like keeping a lit match in the hay," Malakar said.

"It's like keeping a preacher in a tavern," said Rook, "if the preacher were right."

They were standing in the corridor, the two of them and Caelen, at the foot of the stair that led up to the council chamber, where the voices had been going for three hours behind the door. It had begun quietly. It had not stayed quiet. Every few minutes a sentence broke out of the room, loud and ragged, and was swallowed again. He heard Vesh's thin exact voice, and Ibb's old dry one, and once, very loud, the Reeve's, saying *no.*

"You'd think they'd have decided by now," said Rook.

"They decided three hundred years ago," Malakar said. "What they're doing is finding out what they decided."

They were called in at the fourth hour. Caelen went alone.

The chamber had changed. The shutters were open, and the evening light came in slantwise and gold across the plank floor and the black table, and the eleven chairs in their horseshoe had been pushed back, as though the men and women in them had stood up and sat down again too many times. The lamp-keepers had gone. There were only the council left, and the clerks along the wall, and the Brine-Reeve in the middle, in the big chair, with his heavy hands flat on the wood. Vesh sat at the left end with his spectacles in his fist. Ibb sat beside him, bolt upright, with his hands in his sleeves. Tamsin stood at the back, by the door, in her blue sash, with ink on her cheek and a face as white as paper.

"Mister Caelen," Hask said. "You will forgive the state of us."

"I'd like to help if I can."

"You may. I will tell you what has happened, and you will tell me if I misstate it." He took a long breath. "The council is divided. Four are for the Reeve's view, that the Guild must be refused and the pockets sealed again for another three hundred years, with the lamps kept, and the world told nothing. Four are for the Harbor-Master's, that the sleepers must be woken, carefully, and soon, by whatever means can be found, before the Guild finds its own. Two are for the Superior's, that the sleepers are sacred, and must be brought to the Honey Chapel, and tended there, in ceremony, until the tide-priests can decide. And one," his eyes went, without malice, to the youngest of the council, a stout red-faced shipwright in a leather apron, "wants to hear what the Guild will pay."

"I did not say pay," said the shipwright, with dignity. "I said *offer.*"

"That is eleven." Hask closed his hands. "It is not an argument. It is a drowning."

They put the questions to him one at a time, and he answered them as honestly as he could.

Ibb asked whether the sleepers felt pain. Caelen said he did not know, that the ones he had touched seemed to dream. Ibb asked whether he believed they were holy. Caelen said that he did not believe in holy, but that he had no word for what they were except *people.* The shipwright asked what the Guild's offer might be worth, and Caelen said he had no idea, and that he had been offered money by the Guild once, in a spring, through a woman called Kell, and had kept the brass token for two years and never spent it. Someone laughed. The sound did not last.

It was Vesh who asked the question. He did it quietly, at the end, with his eyes on the table.

"You were woken," he said. "As they would be. Will you tell the council how it was?"

The chamber was very still. Caelen looked at the Harbor-Master's thin shaking hands, and at the Reeve's stone face, and at the little knot of clerks by the door; and he understood that this was the question the council had been circling for four hours without saying it aloud. They had been arguing about what to do with a hundred and nine. They had not asked what it was to be one.

"A blast woke me," he said.

His voice came out steady. He had not been sure that it would.

"I was in a seam in a Guild mine, in the deep strata, sealed in marrow-glass. The Guild set a charge. It broke the stone. I remember heat, and sound, and being thrown out of the dark into a place with no walls. I couldn't stand. I couldn't breathe. My body had been one shape for as long as I could remember, and I'd been torn out of it. I ran. I don't know how. There was water coming in, and men screaming, and I got to the top, and I was alone in a forest in the rain." He stopped. "It was the worst thing I've ever felt. I didn't know the word for it. I've been afraid every day since that it wasn't over."

"And yet you lived," Ibb said.

"A man found me. He fed me. He didn't ask me for anything." Caelen met the old clerk's eyes. "I think that's all it was. I think anyone would have lived, if someone had sat with them. The seven who didn't —"

He stopped. He had not meant to say it. He saw Vesh's head come up.

"Seraphina's found something," he said. "She's still working it out. I'd rather she told you herself. But I'll say this much. I don't think waking kills. I think waking *alone* does."

The council broke on that.

It did not break cleanly. It broke the way a wave breaks on a shelf of rock, in noise and spray and a sudden fierce confusion, and for a little while Caelen stood in the middle of the floor and let it go over him. Ibb was on his feet, saying that the sleepers were not Caelen's to speak for. The shipwright was saying, *if there is a way, if there is truly a way* — Vesh was saying, in a thin cracked unfamiliar voice, *a hundred and nine, a hundred and nine, I have a hundred and nine in the margin* — and over all of it came the Reeve, who had not moved, who had not raised his voice, who struck his open hand once on the black oak table with a sound like a gunshot.

"Enough."

It stopped.

"I will say what I fear." The deep slow voice came flat and heavy into the silence. "I would like it written down, Harbor-Master. I would like the whole council to hear it. Then you may vote how you like."

He stood up. He was a very big man. He put his hands behind his back and looked, not at the council, but at the open window, at the long gold evening and the cliff beyond it with its small lit lamps.

"My father told me, on the last night he lived, that we were the keepers of a door. I have thought about that every day for twenty-six years, and I have never been sure what he meant. I think I know now." A pause. "I do not fear the Guild. I fear what it will bring. I fear that a grey ship and a good man and a list of names will be the end of a promise that three hundred years of my people have kept in the dark, with their own hands, for nothing. *We'll not wake what we can't keep.* That was the vow. Not *we will never wake.* We *can't keep them.* Do you understand? Not one of us has the faintest idea how."

"The strata boy —"

"The strata boy lived because he was lucky." The Reeve's eyes did not move. "I do not say it to wound him. He knows. He said it in this room. A man found him in a forest and fed him, and it was one chance in a thousand. And I have a hundred and nine." He swallowed. "If we open the doors, and the children come out, and they die, as seven have died, I will have done it. I will have killed them with my own hand, by lamplight, in the name of mercy. If we leave them where they are, they sleep. They are warm. They are dreaming. Nobody has ever been able to tell me what is wrong with that."

Nobody answered. Outside, the gulls wheeled over the quay.

"It is not the Guild I fear," Hask said, very quietly. "It is that I might be wrong."

They did not vote. There was no way to do it. When the light began to go the Reeve dismissed the council with a gesture and sat down heavily in the big chair, a tired old man with his hands hanging between his knees, and the clerks went out one by one.

Tamsin did not move. She stood by the door with her back against the wall, and when the room had emptied she came forward, slowly, across the plank floor, and stopped in front of the table.

"Reeve."

"Clerk."

"May I say something?"

"You have been wishing to for four hours." He did not look up. "You may."

"Nobody asked her."

He lifted his head.

“All day,” Tamsin said. Her voice shook, and she let it. “All day, you’ve been deciding what to do with a hundred and nine. The Superior wants to put them in the chapel. The Harbor-Master wants to wake them. You want to keep them asleep. The Guild wants to count them. And one of them is awake. She’s been awake four months. She’s sitting in a room above this one with a wooden horse and a name that she gave herself, in front of the whole harbor, and not one person on this council has asked her what she wants.” She drew a breath. “She’s got words. She’s got maybe forty. She can say *no.* She said it today, when the chain went up. I heard her.”

Hask looked at her. The stone had gone out of his face. What was underneath it looked, for the first time, old and bewildered and ashamed.

“She is nine years old,” he said.

“So was he,” said Caelen, behind her.

The Reeve closed his eyes.

“I do not know how to ask her,” he said.

“I do,” said Caelen.

Chapter Three — The Cradle Rite

A note on point of view: this chapter departs from Caelen’s perspective, following Seraphina. See style-guide.md §4.

SERAPHINA

The Honey Chapel had been cut by people who did not know what they were guarding, and Seraphina knew it before she had gone ten steps inside.

It stood at the head of the cliff road, where the gravel ended in a low stone arch, and beyond the arch was a passage that sloped down into the rock. It had no windows. It had no altar. The passage ran for forty paces, wide enough for two people to walk abreast, with a ceiling she could have touched with her hand, and the walls were whitewashed. Every few paces there was an iron bracket and a tallow candle, set there by someone who had been told that holy places required light and had not been told what kind.

"The founders cut it in the fourth year," said Ibb. He walked ahead of them with a lantern, bent a little under the low roof, the old bone-thin man in his blue sash. He had not wanted to come. He had said so, three times, at the arch, and had then picked up the lantern himself. "They had found the first sleeper in the third summer of the harbor. They did not know what she was. They said she was a saint, or a drowned child, or a judgment. They built a place for her to be looked after. It was empty before the first mass of winter."

"Because she died."

"She lived eleven days." He did not turn his head. "I have read the entry every year of my life. It says: *waking*."

Seraphina said nothing. Behind her, Tamsin held the girl's hand, and the girl came on in silence, small and straight in the cut-down smock, her short hair combed flat by someone's careful fingers. Caelen walked at the back. He had asked her last night, in his way, with his few words and his long patience, whether she wanted to see the place they had made for her. She had looked at him for a long time. Then she had taken his hand and walked to the door.

It had been, Seraphina thought, the first decision anyone in the harbor had ever asked her to make. It had taken her four seconds.

They came to the end of the passage and the whitewash stopped.

The chamber beyond was not whitewashed. It was not cut, either. It was a natural cavity in the cliff, round and low, perhaps fifteen paces across, and the walls of it were the walls of the cliff itself, black rock banded with long veins of honey-colored stone. Someone had run a rail round the edge. Someone had set a plain wooden table in the middle, with a candle on it and a bowl of dried flowers, long dead. The air smelled of salt and cold wax.

And the veins glowed.

She had seen marrow-glass in the Vault, vast and slow, in columns that climbed out of sight. She had seen it in a shard on a stone table in a fire-lit camp. She had never seen it like this, running through a wall in a living web, warm to the eye and faintly luminous, like the inside of a hand held over a lamp. It lit the chamber. The candle was unnecessary. The whole space swam in a soft amber dusk, and the shadows of the four of them moved on the stone like fish.

"There," Ibb said.

He held up the lantern. On the wall behind the table, at the height of a standing woman's shoulder, in a smooth band of the honey stone, were marks.

Seraphina crossed the floor without knowing she had moved.

They were cut, not painted. They were cut very fine and very shallow, in a script she had never seen. It ran in a long unbroken spiral from the outer rim of the band inward, like the grooves of a shell, and each character was a curve: a long low wave, a quick rise, a loop, a sustained arch. They did not look like writing. They looked like a drawing of a sound.

Tonal, she thought. *Of course.*

She put out her hand. She did not touch it. The stone was warm against her skin an inch away.

"The founders found it when they dug the passage," Ibb said, behind her. "They thought it was ornament. They built the chapel to face it. The Clerk-Superior of the day made a copy, and the copy was lost, and in the end there was only the wall." A pause. "No one can read it. Not in three hundred years. I have sat in front of it, Archivist, on the eve of a hundred Namings, and asked it to tell me what the sleepers are for."

"And it never answered."

"Not once."

It was the girl who answered.

Seraphina did not see her let go of Tamsin's hand. She only knew that one moment the child was at the clerk's side, and the next she was at the wall, small and quick in the amber light, with both palms flat on the stone. Her head had tipped back. Her eyes were closed. And from somewhere in her thin chest came a sound that Seraphina had heard before, in a whitewashed room, in a hum on the stair: a low, steady, searching note, rising and falling, following the spiral from the outer rim inward.

"Don't touch her," Tamsin whispered.

"She is not hurt."

"Archivist —"

"Look at her face."

It was not the face of a frightened child. It was something Seraphina had seen once before, on an old woman reading a letter in a language she had thought was dead. It was recognition. The girl's lips were slightly parted, and she hummed the spiral through, twice, slowly, and Seraphina saw that each shift in her pitch matched a curve in the stone. She was reading it. She was not reciting it from memory, because she could not have known it. She was reading it by touch, as a blind woman reads a page, the long fine grooves going under her palms like a string of beads.

"Caelen," Seraphina said, very softly. "Take my pencil."

He had it in his hand before she finished. She had not known he was so near.

"Write what I tell you. Pitch and length. Mark where she holds."

She stood at the child's shoulder, with her ear to the music, and listened.

It took an hour.

She would remember it as the most exact work of her life. The girl hummed the spiral through, and then again, and again, a phrase at a time, stopping whenever Seraphina touched her sleeve, and the sound went into Caelen's pencil as a column of small curves, and out of Seraphina's mouth as a string of half-guessed words. She had the grammar from the reliquary fragments. She had the roots from a shard she'd read under a mountain. She had no dictionary and no teacher. She had a nine-year-old with her hands on the wall, humming the language of the dead, and a man beside her who wrote what he was given with a hand that did not tremble once.

By the end she was shaking.

"Read it back," she said. "Please. Slowly."

Caelen read it, from his page, in the flat low voice of a man reading the weather.

We lay them down in the warm. We sing the long note and the stone grows soft. They do not die. They wait. When the cold has passed, let one who is awake sit by them, and sing the long note back, and the stone will open slowly, for nine days, and the sleeper will find the shape of the waking. Do not break. Do not hurry. A broken cradle breaks the child.

The silence went on a very long time.

"Cradle," said Ibb. His voice was a dry thread. "You have written *cradle*."

"It is the nearest word."

"It is —" He stopped. "That is not a tomb."

"No."

"It is not a tomb. It is not a punishment. It is — it has been three hundred years —" He put a hand to the wall to steady himself, and took it away, as though the warmth had burned. "They are not dead. They were never dead. They were *put there*."

"Yes," said Seraphina.

She was crying. She had not noticed. She stood in the soft amber light with the tears running down her face and the whole of it falling into place around her like a ceiling she had been holding up for three years.

The Synod had sealed the fragments because they did not understand them.

That was the first thing. It came to her clean and cold, like the sound of a dropped coin. They had held the half-torn page in the reliquary for generations and read it as a rite for the sick. *A presence held still, while the sleeper finds the shape of the waking.* They had seen the word *sleeper*

and thought *the drifting*. They had seen *anchor* and thought *physician*. They had built a doctrine of suppression on top of a lullaby.

And she had done the same.

She had stood in a stone circle in the Wastes and treated a brass-fitter's drifting mind with a rite that had been written for a child waking in the dark. It had worked. That was the extraordinary part. It had worked, not perfectly, not for long, but it had worked, again and again, on the exhausted and the half-lost, because a mind in drift was in some terrible sense *half-woken,* a thing caught between the shape it had and the shape it was trying to find. The rite had never been a medicine. It had been a midwife's song, and the drifting had simply borrowed it.

Every Resonant is a little bit asleep, she thought, and was cold to the bone.

The Lithoi had not died. They had not been exterminated, or not only. They had known what was coming, and they had done the one thing a dying people can do. They had laid down their young in the warm, in the stone, with a song, to wait out the winter of the world. To be the last. To be the *seed.*

The last of the Lithoi, the old stories called them. She had always heard the phrase as an elegy.

It was a promise.

"There is more," said Tamsin.

She had been crouching by the wall with the girl in her arms for some minutes. The child had gone limp and drowsy against her, the way a child does after long effort, her face pressed into the clerk's shoulder. But she had not stopped humming. It was very faint, a thread of sound at the very bottom of her voice, and Tamsin was looking not at the spiral but at the last few characters, at the very centre, where the cut grooves ran to a point.

"She keeps going back to this," she said. "The end. She goes round and round it and then she stops. And she looks at him." Her eyes went to Caelen. "I think she's saying something."

Seraphina knelt. She laid her ear almost to the stone.

The last phrase was short. It was very low. It ended on a held note that did not resolve, a long falling tone that hung in the air like a question, and she had heard it twice before: once in Caelen's account of a hum in the mine, and once from the girl herself, on the stair, in the first week, on the day he had sat and waited.

She did not need the grammar. She did not need the dictionary. She knew what it meant as she had known the meaning of *stay.*

The held breath.

"What is it?" Caelen said.

She looked up at him, and saw that he already knew.

“A sleeper woken too quickly,” she said slowly, “stops halfway. It is neither in the stone nor out of it. It lives. It walks, it eats, it learns. But it is not finished. It carries the unfinished waking in its body like a held breath. And the held breath must be let go, Caelen, or it —” She swallowed. “The wall does not say what happens if it is not. It only says that it can be.”

“How?”

“By one who sits beside, and sings the long note, for nine days.” Her voice cracked. “And by a second, already woken, who sings the next.”

Caelen stood very still.

On the other side of the amber chamber, in the arms of a tide-clerk, the child lifted her head and looked at him. She was not afraid. She had never been afraid of him.

She held out her hand.

Chapter Four — Grown, Not Touched

He walked out of the chapel, up the long whitewashed passage, past the tallow candles and the cold brackets, and stood on the gravel under the sky for a very long time without knowing what to do with his hands.

It was late afternoon. The cliff road ran away north along the headland in the low gold light, white edge-stones and swept gravel and small tin hoods, and the sea beyond it was the color of a dove’s breast. Gulls turned over the water. A boy was driving goats along the clifftop with a stick. He saw Caelen standing there, and stopped, and took off his cap, and put it on again, embarrassed, and drove the goats on.

Behind him he heard Seraphina come out of the arch. She did not speak. She came and stood a few feet off, with her arms wrapped round her middle, and for a while they looked at the sea together.

"There's more," she said, at last. "I wasn't going to tell you here."

"Tell me."

"The Synod keeps a commentary on the old texts. Four hundred years of glosses. There's a section on a doctrine called *the grown and the touched.* I read it in the reliquary the first winter, in the cold, copying fragments by the light of a lamp that smoked." Her voice was quite level. "It describes two kinds of Resonant. The *touched,* those changed by contact with the marrow, as a man is changed by fever. And the *grown.* Children said to have been formed inside the stone, not changed by it. The commentary calls them a myth. A cautionary tale for Guild crews, to keep them from digging too deep."

"Grown, not touched," Caelen said.

He had said it himself, in a dry shelter, with a scavenger across the fire. *I was grown. In it. Not touched.* He had had the words and not the meaning. They had come up out of the bottom of him like a bubble from deep water.

"I do not think it was a myth," said Seraphina.

"No."

"I think the Lithoi made them. I think that is what the cradle *is.* Not a hiding place. A womb." She turned to face him, and her eyes were brimming, and she did not look away. "Caelen. You were never a child the stone changed. You are one of them. You are the thing they were making in the dark, while the world above was being taken apart."

He did not go to the guest house. He went up.

There was a place above the town where the cliff road bent inland and the grass came down to the edge, a small grassy knoll with a single wind-bent thorn tree, and he lay down under it on his back with his hands open on the turf and watched the sky go from gold to green to the deep, clear blue of a summer night. The first stars came out. The lamps came on along the headland, one by one, and the pulse came up through the ground into his spine, slow and warm, a hundred and nine heartbeats and the sea beneath them.

They sang to me, he thought.

It was the first thing. It came very quietly. He lay there with it, in the dark, and let it unfold.

Somebody had laid him down. Somebody, a long time ago, had stood in a gallery in the dark with a child in their arms and sung a single long note, and the stone had grown soft, and they had put him in it. They had known they would not be there when he woke. They had known the cold would come. And they had done the only thing left to them. They had made a cradle out of the world itself, and trusted that someone, someday, would come and sit by it.

For ten years he had been the child who woke in a mine, torn out of the dark by a charge of black powder, thrown into a forest in the rain. He had told himself it was a thing that had been done to him. He had told himself that he did not know why.

A broken cradle breaks the child.

He understood, now, what he had been running from. It was not the Guild. It had never been the Guild, or the Wardens, or the Synod, or any of it. It was the dark in his own chest. The coal he banked every hour, the vast patient hunger that waited at the edge of every Shift, the undertow that had taken his name at the weigh-station and nearly taken it for good at the Vault. He had thought it was a predator. He had thought it was a sickness he had caught in the mine.

It was an unfinished waking.

It was the held breath. It had been in him for ten years, the whole of him that had never been let out of the stone, pressing up against the part that had been dragged into the light. It was not his enemy. It was his *self.* It was the half of him that still thought it was in the cradle, listening for a song that had never come.

He pressed the heels of his hands against his eyes.

The rage came later, and it was worse than the grief.

It came up in him slowly, in the small hours, with the stars wheeling overhead, and it was cold and clean and entirely without direction. He lay with his teeth set and thought of a blast. A survey crew in the deep strata, a charge set in a wall, a foreman's hand on a lever, a man who had written *recovered asset* in a ledger and gone home to supper. He thought of what had been in that wall. He thought of what had been *broken.*

He thought of all of them. A hundred and nine in the cliff. Seven in the old book, dead in painted rooms. And who knew how many others, in how many seams across the world, taken out of the dark by men with picks and lamps and no idea, and carried up and fed and loved wrongly and watched while they went quiet. The Guild had been blasting cradles for three hundred years. They had been breaking children, and entering them in the loss column under *crew losses, unlicensed.*

His hand closed in the grass. He felt the heat come up behind his sternum and he let it come, just for a moment, because there was no one there to see. The turf under his palm went warm. A thin pale line of scorch ran out from his fingers and died.

Don't, he thought. *Not like this.*

It was Varrick's voice, dry and flat, from a long way off. *Boy, the thing you're angry at doesn't care that you are.*

He lay still. He breathed. It took a long time. When he had put the coal back in its bank, the sky over the sea had begun to lighten, and the stars were going out, and in all that vast pale morning there was no sound but the tide.

He found that he had been thinking about his name.

It was a small thing. It had no business arriving then, with so much else. But it came, out of the grey light, and sat down beside him.

He had had a name in the dark. He had always had it. It was the one thing that had come up out of the stone with him, the first thing he had known, a small warm shape in the mind that he had turned over and over like a pebble. *Caelen.* He had never asked where it came from. He had assumed, in the way of a child, that one simply had a name, as one had hands.

But nobody has a name by themselves.

Somebody had said it to him. Somebody had said it a great many times, over a long time, in the warm, in the dark, until it stuck. Somebody had held him and said, *this is who you are.*

He turned over on the grass, and put his face against the cold dew, and cried for a long time without making a sound.

The girl was awake when he came down.

It was after dawn. The town was stirring, a smoke of breakfast fires rising from the lower lanes, a bell ringing the hour. The white house at the head of the fourth flight had its shutters open. Tamsin lay curled on the floor inside the door under a blanket, asleep with her pencil still in her hand. The wooden horse stood on the sill. And in the middle of the boards, in the pale yellow light, with her legs folded under her and her hands loose in her lap, the child sat looking at the door as though she had been looking at it all night.

He stopped on the threshold. She looked at him. Her eyes went to his face, and then, as they always did, to his chest. But she did not hum. She did not lean. She only looked, and he understood that she had known. That she had been waiting up for him, as he had waited for her. That she knew exactly where he had been all night, and what he had found there, and how long it had taken him to come back.

He crossed the floor and knelt in front of her.

"I'm sorry," he said. His voice cracked. "I don't know how to say it. I didn't know."

She held out her hand.

She laid it flat on his sternum, over the bank, over the place where the coal lay sleeping, and he did not flinch. It was warm. It was very small and very sure. She closed her eyes, and her lips parted, and the hum came up out of her chest and into his.

It was different.

It had been a question, in the beginning. A test, a reading, a thing she had done to find out what he was. Then a word, on the cliff, a low strange note that had gone through him like a hand on the back of the neck. Now it was neither. It was not asking. It was not telling. It went down through his ribs and into the dark behind his breastbone, slow, soft, even, and the coal answered not with

heat but with something he had no name for, a loosening, an unclenching, as though a fist that had been closed for ten years had been very gently, very patiently, told that it could open.

Do not break. Do not hurry.

He felt it. He felt, for the first time since the mountain, something in him that was not afraid.

She did not finish. She sang for the space of a dozen breaths, and then she stopped, and opened her eyes, and sagged against him, small and limp and exhausted, her forehead against his collarbone. He held her. The sun came across the floor. He sat there with his arms round a child who had sung him the first line of the song his own people had left for him, and he did not move, and he did not speak, and it was the first morning of his life that he was glad to be what he was.

"Later," she said, into his coat, in her cracked hoarse voice. "Not now. Later."

"Yes," he said. "Later."

Chapter Five — The Case File of the Sleeping

A note on point of view: this chapter departs from Caelen's perspective, following Malakar. See style-guide.md §4.

MALAKAR

Reth had given him the satchel himself, and that was what made Malakar read it twice.

"All of it," the Chairman had said, in the corridor of the tide-house, with the boy and the boathook watching from the clerk's stool. "The survey, the appendices, the Board's charter, the correspondence. I would like someone to read it who reads as you do. I have never been able to see what

is in a document that I wrote myself." A faint dry smile. "You were an Inquisitor. I am told you could find a flaw in a prayer."

"I could find a flaw in an apology," said Malakar. "It is a different skill."

He took the satchel. He carried it back to the guest house through the dusk, past the fish-wharf and the shuttered net-lofts and the knots of men in salt-stiff coats who stopped talking as he went by, and set it on the table in the room he shared with Rook, and lit the lamp. Rook was asleep on the floor with his coat over his face. Malakar sat down in the one chair, drew out the first sheaf, and began, as he had begun some ten thousand times in the cold north room at Kesh Hollow, with the page numbers.

They were out of order. That was the first thing. A survey of this kind should have been paginated straight through, front to back, in a single clerk's hand. This one had been bound in five different sections, each numbered separately, with a title sheet, two cover letters, and a table of contents that listed an *Appendix F* and gave no page. He turned back. He turned forward. He found, at the back of the fourth section, tucked inside a flap of grey card, a single bundle of eleven sheets with no number on any of them.

Appendix F, said the top one. *Recovery Estimate, Charter 9. For Board circulation only.*

He read it slowly. He read it with his pen in his hand, as he read every document, and by the third page he had put a small cross in the margin, which was his old mark for *this sentence is lying.*

It was a very polite document.

That was the horror of it, and he saw it clearly, sitting in the lamplight with the tide breathing under the floor. There was not one cruel word in it. It was written in the plain, mild, grey language of the Guild's best clerks, the language of tariffs and weights, and it said, in effect, that the Board wished to be of service. It had read the Hall of Canon's finding. It approved of the finding. It proposed, in a spirit of cooperation, to *recover* the persons identified in Survey Section Three, *wherever such recovery may be effected safely, in conformity with the rite recognized by the hall,* at the Guild's expense.

It listed them. It numbered them, with the Ledger's own names, from the Weeping Stair to the Old Mouth. It assigned each pocket a *recovery class,* A through D, according to depth, tidal access, and estimated *occupancy.* It budgeted the cost of the waking in hours of labor and fathoms of rope. It budgeted the cost of *stabilization,* and of *custodial placement,* and of a *transitional household* for each recovered person, with a nurse and a tutor and a physician, in a house on the quay. It was, he thought, almost tender. It might have been written by a good man who had spent his life watching children fall through a floor.

On page six, in a sub-clause of a paragraph headed *Legal Basis,* it said:

F-9. Persons recovered under this Charter shall be entered as wards of the Office of Custody (Guild Division) for the duration of their minority, with all rights and obligations of guardianship, including provision for their maintenance, instruction, and the disposition of remains.

Malakar put down his pen.

He read the sentence again. He read it aloud, under his breath, to hear the grammar, because he had learned long ago that a lie does not live in the nouns. It lives in the verbs, and in who has been left out of them. *Shall be entered.* By whom? *Wards,* of the Guild. *For the duration of their minority.* Which was defined, in a footnote, as *until the ward attains a licensed Resonant status, as determined by the Office.* And at the end, in four words, as quiet and as smooth as a stone in a pocket: *the disposition of remains.*

He sat back.

Remains. A ward of the Guild, raised in a house on the quay with a nurse and a tutor, fed and taught and tenderly loved, who died: what became of the body? A child of the stone. A child of marrow. He thought of Aethel-Cores, cut and graded and sold by the ounce to men with more ambition than sense. He thought of the Culling. He thought of how very well-made it was, this clause, how perfectly it fitted the world the finding had made: a world in which the Guild was a *partner,* a funder of mercy, an honest friend to the drifting. It had taken the language of the hall and turned it, quietly, like a key in a lock.

It is not a hunt, he thought. *It is an adoption.*

And on the last sheet of the bundle, in a clerk's tidy pencil, the figure he had been dreading, as a man dreads the second shoe.

Estimated residual marrow yield, per ward, lifetime: 3.8 stone.

He did not wake Rook. He did not wake anyone.

He put the bundle in his coat, and took his hat, and went out into the night, and walked, without hurry, along the quay and up the stair to the tide-house. The boy with the boathook was asleep on his stool. Malakar stepped over his feet and knocked, twice, on the door at the end of the corridor.

"Come."

Reth was sitting by the window in his shirtsleeves with the shutters open and a candle on the sill. He had not been writing. His hands lay open on his knees. When he saw who it was, he did not rise, and he did not ask, and Malakar understood that he had been sitting there waiting for him since the satchel left his hands.

"You have read Appendix F."

"I have read Appendix F."

"What do you think of it?"

Malakar crossed the room and laid the bundle on the sill beside the candle. He opened it to page six. He put one finger on the sub-clause and did not take it away.

"I think it was written by a man who admired the finding," he said. "I think it was written by a man who wished the recovered children well. I think he was extremely careful. There is not one

unkind word in this document, Chairman, and I have been reading unkind documents for twenty years." He lifted his eyes. "I should like to know if you have read this."

Reth said nothing.

"The wording," Malakar said. "The *disposition of remains.*"

"No."

It was so quiet that he nearly missed it.

"I have not read it." The small grey man looked at the page, and then, with a visible effort, at Malakar. "I read the survey. I read the recommendations. I signed the Charter in February, and the appendices were bound separately, as the Board's practice is, and circulated to the clerks of works. I did not read them. I never read the appendices." His voice cracked, a very small crack, like frost in a cup. "I do not know who wrote this. I could find out. I think I know already."

"You signed it."

"I signed it." He took the page. He read the sub-clause once, slowly, with his lips moving, and Malakar watched the color go out of his face from the forehead down. "*Disposition of remains.*" A long pause. "Forty years, Malakar. I have spent forty years learning the exact weight of that phrase. I have entered it in ledgers. I have *written* it, in that column, in my own hand. And I put my name on a charter that used it as a clause."

"Not knowing."

"It is the same."

"Not quite."

"It is the same to the dead." He laid the page on the sill. His hand was not steady. "I did not write this. I did not intend it. I would not have permitted it for the world. And it has my seal at the bottom of the packet, and a hundred and nine children on the other side of that window who are, tonight, in law, a line in a Board appendix." He looked up. "What do you propose to do with it?"

It was a question Malakar had asked himself in the corridor, and on the stair, and at the quay's edge. He had asked it with the cold clear habit of an Inquisitor, and he had not liked the answer.

He could use it. He could carry the bundle up to the council chamber in the morning, lay it on the black oak table, and read F-9 aloud to eleven frightened people who already half believed it. The Guild would be finished on this coast. Reth would be finished, a man who had given forty years to a column of the unattended and would be remembered as the architect of a trap. It would be the strongest thing he had ever held. He had held such things in the Warden order. He knew exactly what they were for.

He thought of a ruin on a cart road, and a captain who had come alone, and had asked for three names.

"I propose to read it to the council myself," he said. "In the morning. With your leave, or without it."

“With it.”

“You will be asked to answer for it.”

“I know.” The small man straightened. “I should like to. I have not been able to answer for anything since I was twenty-six.” He took up the candle, and the light moved across his face, which was old and tired and, for the first time since Malakar had known him, entirely without defense. “Will you do something for me? Read it as it is. Do not make it worse. I should hate to be judged for a wickedness I had not the wit to commit.”

Malakar looked at him for a long moment.

“I have never read a document otherwise,” he said.

He took the bundle off the sill and went out into the corridor, past the sleeping boy, and down the dark stair. In the street the tide was coming in, a long grey hush under the quay, and above him on the cliff the little lamps burned in their niches like a string of patient eyes. He stood a moment, with the pages against his chest.

He had spent twenty years of his life teaching himself to see the thing that language was built to hide. He had thought of it as a vice, and then as a weapon, and then, lately, as neither. It was only a kind of attention. It was what you gave a document you did not intend to let lie.

It is an adoption, he thought again. *Not a hunt.*

And he went back to the lamp, and sat down, and began to write out what he would say.

Chapter Six — Forty-One

They chose the boy because he was the easiest to reach, and because nobody could bear to choose any other way.

Malakar had read his clause to the council at dawn, in a flat clear voice, with Reth standing white-faced at the end of the table, and the room had gone through three kinds of silence. Then Hask had said, quite quietly, "Strike it, Chairman, or I will strike you," and Reth had taken a pen from the shipwright's hand and drawn a line through *F-9* in front of eleven witnesses, and signed his name beside it. It had not ended the argument. It had made the argument possible. For the first time in two days, nobody was talking about the Guild.

They were talking about the boy.

"The Long Shelf," Vesh said. He stood at the black oak table with the chart unrolled before him, pointing with a pen. "Pocket nineteen. Tidal access at the lowest ebb, a ledge four feet wide, a gallery cut by the lamp-men a hundred and fifty years ago and never opened. One sleeper. A boy, by the margin mark. He was seen in the stone in the year of the Black Tide and noted as *small, curled, dreaming*." His thin hand shook, and he steadied it. "He is the nearest. I do not say he is the best. I say that if a mistake is made, the sea is close."

"That is a cold thing to say," said Ibb.

"It is the only warm thing I have."

The vote was six to five. Hask spoke last. He stood with his big hands flat on the table and did not look at anyone, and said, "One. Not two. If the boy dies, the doors are closed for another three hundred years, and no man on this council will raise a hand against it. I will have your word."

They gave it. Caelen gave it with them, because there was no other way to give a promise of that kind. He looked at the girl, who was sitting in the corner on a stool with her wooden horse, listening to every word with her head tilted. She looked back at him. Then she slid off the stool, and walked across the plank floor, and took his hand.

"Go," she said.

The waking took nine days.

He would remember them as a single long unbroken day, a stretch of grey light and green water and the endless soft sound of two voices. They went down on the first morning at dead low tide, down a rope ladder to the ledge, six of them in oilskins with lamps: Caelen, the girl, Seraphina, Tamsin, Vesh with a ledger on a board, and the old lamp-keeper Nessa, who had said nothing, but had arrived at the foot of the cliff at dawn with her oil-can and a net-needle and a basket of bread.

The Long Shelf was a slot in the cliff. It was dry on the ledge itself, barely, with a black overhang above and a skirt of weed below and the sea breathing a yard from their boots. Behind them the lamp-men's gallery went back into the rock, narrow and low, hung with old iron brackets. Halfway along, at the height of his knee, the wall was banded with honey stone. And at the end of it, where the gallery closed, there was a niche in the cliff the size of a child's bed.

He was lying in it.

Caelen knelt and held his lamp up, and the light went into the stone like honey into water. He could see the shape of him, a small curled body in a smoothness of amber, not a statue and not a corpse, but a thing that had been put down very gently and told to wait. A thin boy of nine or ten with his knees drawn up and one hand under his cheek. His hair was long. His mouth was a little open. And through the stone, faint and slow and regular, there came a pulse.

"Hello," Caelen said softly. He did not know why. "I'm here. We're here."

He sat down, cross-legged, on the wet rock, at the head of the niche. The girl sat down opposite him with her palms flat on the stone. Seraphina took the foot of it. Nessa set a lamp on a bracket, and trimmed it, and for the first time in his hearing she began, very quietly, to tell the tide.

Low water. Nine hours until the turn. The wind is south and cold. The sea is calm.

He closed his eyes. He found the long note.

It was the hardest thing he had ever done, and the least like anything he had done before.

It was not a Shift. There was no tearing, no fire, no lengthening of hands. There was a coal in his chest, small and banked, and a long low sound in his throat, and a child asleep in a rock. He sang. He held the note. It was neither high nor low; it was exactly the pitch of the sea beneath them, and he found that he knew it. His body had known it all his life. He let it go out of him slowly, a thread, into the stone, and felt the stone answer.

On the first day, nothing changed. On the second, the honey stone grew a little warmer under his palm. On the third, the pulse in the niche changed its rhythm, from the slow sleeping beat to something quicker and lighter, the heartbeat of a child at the edge of waking, and Seraphina whispered, *there.* On the fourth day, the girl sang the next phrase.

He had not asked her to. He had not known she could. She sat opposite him in her cut-down smock with her eyes closed and her thin hoarse voice rose, a half-step above his, tracing the second line of the song, the one the wall had said was hers. They sang together for six hours. When the tide came in and the ledge went under, they were carried up the ladder with their hands still pressed to the stone, and sang on the clifftop, in the rain, under oilcloth, and in the night when the others slept, because the boy would not wait.

He did not eat. He drank when Tamsin held a flask to his mouth. He slept in snatches, sitting up, against the rock. He felt the cold coming for him the way it always did, creeping up from the marrow, and he held it off with the long note and the small warm bank of the coal, and he thought of nothing but the child.

On the sixth day the stone began to soften.

It was Nessa who saw it first. She had gone quiet the previous evening, and stopped telling the tide, and sat with her back against the rock and her eyes on the amber, and now she said, very low, "Look."

The honey stone around the boy's hand had turned the color of warm wax. It had lost its edge. A faint translucence crept outward from the fingers, spreading, a flush like blood under skin. The surface rippled. Caelen watched it, and felt the pulse under his palm rise, and rise, and hold.

Do not break. Do not hurry.

"Steady," Seraphina whispered. "Steady. Don't push it. Let him come."

It happened on the ninth morning, at the turn of the tide.

The sea had been rising for an hour. The ledge was awash to their ankles. Nobody had spoken for a long time, and the two voices, the man's and the child's, had fallen together into a single sound, a low rolling chord that filled the gallery and the niche and the slot of grey sky above. Caelen had stopped feeling his hands. He had stopped feeling his knees. He was a note, held in the dark, and he was not afraid.

The stone parted.

It did not crack. It did not break. It opened the way a flower opens, in a long slow unfolding, the amber softening and drawing back from the small body like water from a stone, until the boy lay in a hollow of warm honey-colored glass with nothing between him and the air. He was thin. He was naked. His skin was the color of tea. His eyelids fluttered.

He drew breath.

It was a ragged, shuddering, astonished gulp, like a swimmer coming up from the bottom of the sea. His chest heaved. His eyes opened, enormous and dark and gold-flecked, and went from the lamp to the rock to the sea, and came to rest on the face above him.

"It's all right," Caelen said. His voice was a ruin. "It's all right. I'm here. Don't —"

The boy screamed.

It was the scream of a child who does not know where he is. It rang off the cliff. His whole body arched and twisted, and the honey bands in the gallery wall flared white, and Caelen felt the heat come, the dreadful old heat, the coal about to break its bank, and he thought, *no, not now, not like this* — and a small hand closed on his sleeve.

The girl had not let go of the song.

She was kneeling at the boy's head with her palms on either side of his face, humming, in the high thin voice that had learned to hold his note. It was not the long note. It was a new one, a little soft rising phrase, three tones and a fall. The boy stopped screaming. His eyes went to her face, huge and wet and bewildered. She hummed it again. And he, with a shaking, uncertain, astonished mouth, hummed it back.

Nessa had put her hand over her face. Vesh was weeping openly, without noise, the way a man weeps who has not done it in thirty years. Tamsin was on her knees in the water, saying something over and over that was not a word.

Caelen did not move. He sat on the wet rock, with the sea coming in round him, and let the small warm bank of the coal settle quietly back into itself. It had not broken. It had not so much as flickered. He was cold, and spent, and utterly empty, and across the narrow gallery two children were humming at each other in a language older than any harbor, and one of them was alive who had been asleep since before the Culling.

He's fine, he thought. *He's just fine.*

It was the first time in all the years he could remember that the song had simply worked.

Chapter Seven — Three Hundred Years

A note on point of view: this chapter departs from Caelen's perspective, following Brine-Reeve Hask — a controlled exception, given to the man whose fear the book owes a hearing. See style-guide.md §4.

HASK

He walked the cliff road at night, alone, as his father had, and counted the dead.

There were forty-three of them, and he knew the stones by feel. They stood on the seaward shelf below the signal-post, where the headland ran out and the rock fell sheer to the Teeth, a small bare plateau of salt-bitten turf with a low drystone wall round it and no tree for a mile. The keepers lay there. Not the Reeves; the Reeves lay in the town graveyard, in rows, with their ledger numbers and their long brave epitaphs. These were the others. The ones who had held the door.

They had no names on their stones. That was the custom. Each was a flat grey slab, set upright in the turf, with a single mark scratched in the face: a small upright stroke, and a slash across. He had never been told what the mark meant. He had known since he was nine years old. He ran

his thumb down the nearest one, in the dark, as another man might touch a rosary, and the cold went up his arm.

One, he thought. *And one. And one.*

His father was the forty-first. The stone was new, as stones went. It was twenty-six years old, and the lichen had barely begun. Hask stood before it with his hat in his hand and the wind coming off the sea, and did not speak for a long time.

He had been sixteen when the old man first took him down to the Long Shelf.

It was the autumn before the herring failed. They had gone at dead low water with a lantern, down the lamp-men's ladder to the ledge, and his father had put him on his knees before the niche at the end of the gallery and said, in the harsh low voice he used for the things he could not say, *look.* Hask had looked. He had seen, in the lantern light, in the glow of the honey stone, a boy of his own age, curled in the amber like a seed in a nut. He had seen the small slow pulse in the wall. He had thought it a corpse.

He's not, his father had said. *None of them are.* A long breath. *We are not the owners of this, Hask. We are the keepers of the door.*

What's behind it?

Nothing, said his father. *That's the burden. We don't know. We know that it must not be opened by the wrong hand. And we know that the right hand has never come.* He had put his big scarred palm flat on the stone. *When I am gone it will be you. You will light the lamp. You will tell the tide. And one day somebody will come and ask you to open it, and you will say no. Because you will not know how. And because a keeper who opens a door he cannot close has not kept it.*

He had said no, for twenty-six years. He had said it to the Salt Office and the Synod's clerk and the Guild's polite men, and to a priest from the cathedral at Marrow Bay who had wept and quoted scripture. He had said it to his own wife, who had wanted him to give the sleepers a chapel. He had never once felt that he was lying.

Three hundred years, he thought. *And not one of us has known how.*

They had woken the boy on the ninth day, in the grey of the morning, and Hask had not gone down.

He had stood on the clifftop above the Long Shelf in his salt-stiff coat with his hands behind him and a hundred of his people silent beside him in the dawn, and watched the tide come in. He had not been able to see the ledge. He had seen only the six oilskinned figures going down the ladder, nine days ago, and the lamp at the foot, and the small steady yellow light that had burned there night and day since, like a heart. He had heard the song. It had come up out of the slot in the rock for nine days, the man's voice and the child's, thin and clear and endless, and the women of the lower town had stopped at their doors to listen, and the fishermen had come in early from the boats.

He had thought, *they will kill him.* He had thought it every hour. He had stood on the cliff with that thought in his belly like a stone, and he had counted the stones in the graves in his head.

At the turn of the tide, he had heard the scream.

It had gone through him like a hook. It was the cry of a child waking in a place he did not know, and his whole body had moved before his mind, and he had been at the head of the ladder with one boot on the rung and his hand clenched on the rope, ready to go down and take the boy out of the hands that had broken him — when the song had changed.

It was a small new sound. It was three tones and a fall. And out of the slot in the rock, thin and shaky and astonished, a second voice, a boy's, had answered it.

Hask had stopped.

He had stood on the ladder with his hand on the rope and the sea in his ears. He had heard the old keeper's voice, Nessa's, rise from the bottom of the shaft, cracked and wild, saying something over and over that was not a prayer. He had heard a man weeping. And he had understood, slowly, in the cold light, that the stone in his belly had gone.

It had not been replaced by anything. It was only gone.

He had gone down the next evening, when the tide-house had sent word that the boy was sleeping.

They had put him in the infirmary on the upper floor, in a clean white bed by an open window, with a clerk to sit by him and the girl curled at the foot with her wooden horse. The boy was thin and brown and small. He lay on his back with his mouth open, breathing slowly, and one hand flung out on the sheet. Hask stood in the door in his coat and did not know what to do with his hat.

The girl looked up. She regarded him gravely. She had seen him in the great hall, in the crowd on the quay, and once through a window with the chain going up behind him. He saw her take the measure of him and decide.

She put one finger to her lips.

"I will not wake him," he said, in a whisper. It was the first time he had spoken to her. "I only —"

He stopped. There was nothing to finish the sentence with.

She slid off the bed and came across the boards in her bare feet and stood in front of him, a head and a half shorter than his belt. She looked up. Then she took the hand that held his hat, quite deliberately, and turned it over, and pressed her small palm into his. It was warm. It was very warm. It was as warm as the stone at the Long Shelf. She held it there, and her lips moved, and she said, in her hoarse cracked careful voice, one of her forty words.

"*Stay.*"

He could not answer. He stood in the white doorway with a nine-year-old's hand in his, in the smell of salt and linen and warm child, and found that his eyes were running and his chin was shaking and he could not make it stop.

He went back to the shelf of stones before midnight.

He did not know why. He had told himself he would see to the lamps. He had trimmed the Old Mouth himself for twenty-six years, a thing he had never told the council, nor the lamp-keepers either, because a Reeve who trims a lamp is a Reeve who has been caught being afraid. He had done it every night, in the dark, with his own oil-can. His father had done it before him.

He stood before the forty-first stone.

I was wrong, he thought. He tried the words, in his own mind, to see how they sat. They sat badly. *I was wrong about the door.*

It had never been a door to be kept shut. That was the thing. He saw it plainly now, in the dark, in the wind. His father had said *keepers,* and he had heard *guards,* and for three hundred years every Reeve in this harbor had stood with his back to the rock and his face to the world, holding the handle. And all the time it had been a door to be opened, one day, by the right hand, in the right way. A door held for someone.

He did not say what to do when the right hand came, he thought, and a thin, bitter, almost-laugh rose in his chest. *He said I would not know. He was right. I did not know.*

But I do not have to know. I only have to let them in.

It was a sentence he could not have said a week ago. It sat in his mouth like a stone he could finally spit. He stood with his palm on his father's cold grave and the sea roaring below, and was a very old man, and a very young one, and did not move.

The light was on the clifftop when he lifted his head.

It was a small light, a mile north, up on the headland above the signal-post. Not a lamp-keeper's yellow. A cold, pale, steady glow, like the light of a shuttered lantern with a brass hood, and it moved. It went along the clifftop in a slow line. It stopped. It moved again.

Hask stood very still.

He had given his word, in front of eleven witnesses, in his own council chamber. *No instrument, no charge, no tool of the Guild to be landed on this coast.* He had posted a man at the quay. He had had the *Tally's* skiff watched since the chain went down. And a mile up the headland, in the dark, a light was moving along the edge of the cliff exactly where the grey painted stakes stood in their little line.

He counted the places the light stopped. One. Two. Three.

The Drowned Bell, he thought. *They are at the Drowned Bell.*

He took his hat from his belt and put it on. Then he turned and walked up the cliff road, not fast, an old man in a salt-stiff coat, toward the light, with his father's key in his pocket and forty-three stones at his back. He did not call out. He did not run.

He had stood at that door for twenty-six years, and for the first time he knew exactly what he was guarding it from.

Chapter Eight — What Reth Offers

They brought the instruments to the council in a fish-crate, and laid them on the black oak table like evidence at a trial.

There were four. A brass theodolite no bigger than a man's head, packed in felt. A folding level. A coil of graduated chain. And a small, sealed, lead-lined box with a screw-down lid, which Hask had not opened, and which he set down in the middle of the table with great care, as a man puts down an egg.

"I found them at the Drowned Bell," he said. "At the third hour of the morning. Four men, with a shuttered lantern. They said they were taking bearings." His deep slow voice was perfectly steady. "They had a tripod set, with a plumb line over the edge, and a hole bored in the turf a hand deep, and that." He nodded at the box. "I did not ask what was in it. I took it."

Nobody spoke. Reth stood at the end of the table in his plain grey coat. He had not slept. He looked at the little lead box for a long moment with an expression that Caelen, standing against the back wall with Rook and Malakar, could not read, and then he said, very quietly:

"May I?"

"No," said Hask.

"Then I will ask you to open it. In front of the council. I would rather not be the one." A pause. "I know what it is. I would like you all to see."

Hask unscrewed the lid. He did it slowly, with big careful fingers. Inside, on a bed of felt, was a stick of grey waxed paper the length of a man's hand, with a short fuse coiled beside it, and a brass cap.

"A test charge," said Reth.

The silence was complete.

"Engineer-Captain Halse is aboard my ship," he said. "I gave him my written order, in my own hand, on the twenty-first night. *Not a single charge.* He told me he would convey it to the party. I took that for a refusal." He lifted his eyes. "I did not think he would go ashore the same night. I should have. It is how a very reasonable man disobeys."

"He has broken the harbor's law," said Hask.

"He has."

"I could arrest him."

"You could hang him, if you wished, under the Salt Office statute. I would hold the rope." The small grey man's voice did not rise. "It would not help. The Board would send another. It would send three, in the spring, with a warship. This is what I came to say, Reeve. It is the thing I could not say on the quay. May I say it now?"

Hask looked at him for a long moment. Then he sat down.

"I cannot stop the survey," Reth said.

He said it to the council, standing, with his hands clasped lightly in front of him, in the voice of a man reading a sentence. "I want that on the record before anything else. I have tried, and I have failed. The Board holds orders that predate my suspension, and in the Board's practice an old order can be countermanded only by the whole Board in session. The whole Board does not sit until November. The gales close the roads before that. If the harbor refuses me, it will be surveyed this autumn by blast, by men who are not wicked, who have never been told what is in the cliff, and I will not be able to prevent a single charge."

"Then why do you stand there?" Ibb said, in his dry old voice. "You have just told us you are powerless."

"I am. Over the Board." Reth turned to him. "I am not powerless over the thing the Board is *for*."

He drew a folded paper from his coat. He did not give it to anyone. He held it for a moment between his fingers, small, grey, creased with many folds, and then laid it on the table beside the lead box.

"The Guild exists to extract," he said. "It does not know how to do anything else. I have spent forty years trying to teach it to do one thing differently, and I have failed, and I am too old to

try again. But the Guild also follows its own law, with great fidelity. The Hall of Canon's finding says that persons of the rite may be recovered under the hall's registry, at public expense, by trained hands, in the open, with a roll. That is law. The Board is bound by it. If the Guild were to recover your sleepers *under the finding,* at its own cost, on the hall's roll, under your Reeve's seal, then the survey becomes redundant. There would be nothing left to survey. The cliff would be a house of treatment." He stopped. "I propose that the Guild fund and staff the waking of every sleeper on this coast. Openly. Slowly. Nine at a time, over three years, with your Harbor-Master's Ledger as the register, and your Reeve as the authority on the ground. The Guild would pay for the physicians, the houses, the food. It would hold no guardianship. It would claim no remains. It would take nothing."

"F-9," said Malakar, from the wall.

"Struck. Initialed. Witnessed." Reth did not turn his head. "I have a second copy, with the Master of the Salt Office's seal on it, in the satchel."

Caelen felt something shift in the room, a loosening, like ice breaking up in a river. He looked at Hask. The Reeve was staring at the folded paper with his heavy hands flat on the oak.

It was, he thought, the most intelligent thing he had ever heard a man say.

He saw it whole, in the grey light of the chamber, with the sea moving under the floor. Reth had not come to take. He had come to give. He had walked into the harbor with his hands open, and read the names of the pockets, and said *refuse me,* and now he stood before them, small and plain, and said *use me.* He had found a place where the Guild's oldest appetite and its newest conscience met, and he had stood on it. It was the same thing he had done in the Spire. He had made mercy and extraction the same line in a ledger, and he had done it honestly, and he would very likely save a hundred and nine lives.

And it will not be enough, Caelen thought, with a cold sudden certainty. *Because of the one thing he can't give.*

He stepped forward.

"May I ask something?"

"Please," said Reth.

"If we take your money. If the Guild pays for the houses, and the physicians, and the food. Who decides when to wake a pocket? And who decides when not to?"

"The Reeve."

"And if the Reeve says no?"

"Then the Reeve says no."

"And the Board?"

Reth was silent.

"You can't promise me that," Caelen said, gently. "You said it yourself. The whole Board doesn't sit until November. You can fund the houses. You can pay the physicians. You can strike a clause and sign it in front of a Reeve. But you can't promise me that when the Board sits, and sees the Guild's name on a hundred and nine wards, and a hundred and nine marrow-sleepers who might, in thirty years, be worth four stone apiece to a man who isn't you, it won't read your charter differently." He took a breath. "I'm not saying you'd lie. I'm saying you're one man."

"Yes," Reth said. It came out quite plainly. "I am."

"Then I'll say what I said in the Hall of Canon." Caelen's voice shook, and he let it. "Fund the door. Don't hold it. Pay for the physicians. Pay for the houses. Put the money in the Ledger's keeping, in escrow, under the Reeve's seal, and let nobody wearing the Guild's grey set foot on this headland with an instrument or a charge. Not Halse. Not his party. Not you. And if you want to know why —" He stopped.

The girl had come in.

He had not heard her. She stood at his elbow, small and quiet, in her cut-down smock, with the wooden horse under her arm. Tamsin hovered in the doorway behind her, looking stricken. The council had turned. Every head in the tight little room.

She looked at Reth.

She had never seen him up close. She studied him, gravely, from his plain grey coat to his tired grey eyes, with the same deliberate care she had given the faces on the quay, and Reth, to his everlasting credit, did not look away.

"*No,*" she said.

It was perfectly clear. It was one of her forty words. She said it without anger, without fear, with a kind of absolute calm. And then, because she was nine, and had only forty, she put out one finger and pointed at the lead box on the table, and said the other word she had that fitted.

"*Hot.*"

They voted at dusk.

It was seven to four. The Guild's money would come, in escrow, under the Ledger's seal. The Guild's physicians would come, Tam the clerk would come, and a nurse, a tutor, and a doctor from the Spire whom Seraphina would name. No instrument. No charge. No Guild survey party. Halse's men were to be off the headland by the morning tide, and the *Tally* was to weigh anchor and stand out beyond the Teeth, and Reth himself, if he wished to stay, would stay as the guest of the Reeve, under the harbor's law, with a boy and a boathook.

Reth bowed. His face was grey with fatigue. He said, "I accept," in a voice that cracked on the second word, and sat down heavily in the nearest chair, an old man who had been standing for two days.

It should have been over. It was the best that could have been made of it. Caelen stood at the window as the lamps came on along the cliff, and Rook came up and leaned beside him, and for a minute neither spoke.

"It's good," Rook said, finally. "Isn't it? It's the right thing."

"It's the right thing."

"Then why's the hair standing up on my neck?"

Caelen did not answer. He was looking at the sea.

The sky to the south had gone a strange color. It was a dull bruised yellow-green, low on the horizon, like the underside of a leaf, and above it the wind-streaked cloud was moving fast, much too fast, in long parallel bars toward the land. The air had that heavy, listening quality he had known before. The gulls had gone from the quay. The water in the harbor mouth lay flat and oily, without a ripple, and beyond the Teeth, very far out, a thin white line was forming where there should have been none.

Hask had come to the window. He stood with his big hands behind him, looking out, and his weathered face was quite still.

"That is early," the Reeve said. "That is a month early."

"What is?"

"The gales," said Hask. "They are coming in off the sea."

Behind them, on the table, the little lead box sat in the lamplight with its lid open and its grey stick of paper lying in the felt like something asleep.

Chapter Nine — The Storm Season

The gale struck at the fourth hour of the night, and by the fifth the harbor was a throat full of white water.

Caelen woke to it in the dark of the guest house with the whole building shuddering round him like a ship. The shutters were banging. Rain came through the roof-tiles in thin hard streams. He lay for a moment listening to the wind, which did not howl but screamed, on one long rising note, and underneath it a deeper sound, a vast slow grinding, that was the sea beating on the Teeth. Then he was on his feet and dressed, and Rook was beside him, and Malakar in the doorway with a lantern, all of them wordless.

"The *Tally*," said Malakar.

"Dragged her anchor," said Rook, from the window. "I can see her lights. She's going down on the breakwater."

She was not. They watched, from the top of the stair, as the long grey ship swung at the end of her cable in the screaming dark, bow to the wind, and held. Her lamps swung like a pendulum. A boat had put out from the quay, and then another, and then the first came scudding back, and a voice shouted that no skiff could cross the roads tonight, not with the sea like this. The Guild's engineers were off the headland by order of the council. They had not been taken aboard. They had never reached the ship.

"Where are they?" said Caelen.

Nobody answered. Then Corwin appeared at the foot of the stair, soaked to the skin, his good grey coat black with rain and a lantern in his fist, and said in a high strange voice, "Nessa's boy

came down the cliff road. He says there's a light on the headland. At the Drowned Bell. He says it's *burning.*"

He ran.

He had not known he could still run like that. He had slept four hours in nine days, and eaten almost nothing, and the cold was in his bones like a second skeleton, but his legs went out from under him on the stair and carried him down it three steps at a time, and then he was in the lane with the rain driving into his face like thrown gravel and the others strung out behind him in the dark.

The cliff road was a river. The gravel had washed out in long gullies, and the white edge-stones stood up out of the flood like teeth. To the left, the headland fell away into a black roaring void where the sea beat on the rock and flung spray fifty feet into the air. To the right, along the cliff face, the little lamps were all lit. Every one. They burned in their tin hoods through the storm, steady, gold, undisturbed, forty-one tiny flames in a night that had put out the stars. Nessa's people had been out since midnight with oil-cans, and had not let one fail.

He ran past them. He felt each one go by. He felt, under his feet, in the soaking road, the entire cliff beginning to sing: not the slow sweet murmur of the nights before, but a thin high rising tone, like a string drawn tight, a hundred and nine hearts all beating faster. They knew. They could feel it, the way he could feel it: something wrong in the stone.

Hold, he thought. *Hold. I'm coming.*

"Caelen!" Rook, behind him, hoarse. "Wait — the girl —"

He turned. She was at his heels.

He had not seen her follow. She was in her oilcloth, a small drenched figure with the wooden horse buttoned inside her coat, running flat out through the flood with her mouth set and her eyes huge and gold in the lantern-light. Tamsin was two strides behind her, white-faced, a rope round her shoulders and a lamp in her hand.

"She heard," Tamsin gasped. "She was at the window. She just — *went.*"

He did not argue. There was no time. He reached out without breaking stride and took the girl's hand, and her fingers closed on his, hot and hard, and together they ran on into the dark.

The Drowned Bell lay beyond the signal-post, where the cliff dipped and the road ran down to a ledge above the sea.

He saw the light first. It was a small red spark, low on the turf at the cliff's edge, in the lee of a boulder, hissing in the rain. A fuse. Someone had been very careful with it. They had laid a length of tarred cord down a groove in the rock and under an oilcloth to keep it dry, and it was burning, a bright steady bead of fire, toward a hole in the ground.

There were three men by the boulder. They had a shuttered lantern and a canvas tarpaulin and the kind of look that people have when they have been caught doing something sensible. One of them was a square sandy man in a grey coat, with whiskers, who was holding a pocket-watch.

"Halse!" Caelen shouted.

The Engineer-Captain turned. He did not look afraid. He looked tired, and wet, and extremely reasonable.

"Stand clear!" he called. "It's a relief charge! The seam is unstable, the storm is working it, there's a pocket of gas under the shelf — we've got to vent it before the cliff goes!"

"It's not gas!"

"It's a periodic anomaly, we've measured it —"

"It's *people!*"

The watch in Halse's hand swung. The man beside him, young, with a rain-streaked face, looked from the fuse to the stranger running at him through the dark, and something in his expression broke. He started to say something. Caelen did not hear it. He saw only the red bead of fire, burning inch by inch along the cord, and judged the distance with the part of him that had been judging distances in dark mines for ten years.

Forty feet. Thirty seconds. Less.

"Rook!" he roared.

Rook was already past him. He went like a thrown knife, low and flat and silent, across the sodden turf, with his coat flying, and Malakar behind him; and Halse, startled, swung round with his arms flung out to bar the way, and Malakar hit him at the knees. They went down together in a tangle in the mud. Rook leaped the boulder. He had his knife out. The fuse lay at his feet, burning, a handsbreadth from the hole, and he threw himself on it, and slashed.

The blade went through the cord.

The flame went on.

It was an old trick. The engineers had known their business. The tar-cord was a double core, with a slow-match inside the outer skin, and the cut did not stop it; the red bead leaped the gap and sped, hissing, along the inner core, down into the bored hole, and was gone.

Rook rolled away on his hands and knees, screaming a word Caelen could not hear.

He understood, in the next instant, exactly what was about to happen. He had understood it in the forest, nine years old, in the dark, in the wet. He saw it whole.

The hole went down into the pocket. At the bottom of the hole was a stick of grey waxed paper. When it went, the stone would shatter. The shell of honey glass that held the sleepers would break into a thousand pieces, and what was in it would be flung out into the storm, into the sea, broken,

torn, alone in the dark. It would be the Long Shelf, but wrong. It would be every one of the seven. It would be him.

A broken cradle breaks the child.

He dropped on his knees at the cliff's edge, in the mud and the rain, and slapped both palms flat on the turf.

The cliff screamed. He felt it come up through his hands: three of them, close together, curled in the dark, in the warm. Three small hearts, going fast. Three sleepers asleep in the Drowned Bell, in the glass, in the stone, who did not know.

He had no time. He had no song. He had a coal in his chest and a breath and a note.

He sang.

It was not the long note. It was the first sound he had ever made, in the dark, under a mountain, before there were words. It tore out of him raw and wide and wordless, into the screaming wind, and he felt it go down through the earth like a spike, and he felt the stone take it. He reached down, down through the root of the cliff, toward the three small hearts. *Hold. Hold. I have you. Hold.*

A small hand closed on his.

The girl had knelt beside him. She had thrown her arms round his arm, her face pressed to his sleeve, her whole thin body shaking with the effort. She opened her mouth, and a note came out of her, high and clear and impossibly steady, a half-step above his, and the two sounds met and locked in the dark like a hand in a hand. Her palm was on the stone. His was on hers.

Beneath them, in the hole, a spark reached the end of a cord.

He did not see it. He did not hear it. There was a sound that was not a sound, a vast soft pressure, like a hand clapped over the world; and a flash that turned the rain to silver; and then the cliff rose up under his knees like the back of a living animal, and threw them into the dark.

Chapter Ten — The Third Pocket

For a long time there was no sound at all.

He lay on his back in the mud with the rain falling into his open eyes and knew only that it was falling. He could see it. It came out of a sky the color of slate in long silver threads, each one separate, each one slow. He lifted a hand and it moved through the air as if through water. There was a high clean ringing in his skull like the note of a struck glass, and beneath it, very far off, an enormous silence, as though the world had been taken away and a picture of the world left in its place.

Count, he thought. It was Varrick's voice. *Count what you've got.*

He had hands. He had both. He had a body, cold and aching and wet, that obeyed him. He rolled over and got up on his elbows and the turf slid under them, and the ringing flooded back in, and with it sound: the scream of the wind, the thunder of the sea, a woman's voice shouting a name over and over. The cliff-edge was gone.

It had not gone far. A slab of turf the size of a wagon had slid forty feet down the slope and hung there, grey and raw and trailing roots. Where the boulder had stood, there was a crater. The air above it smelled of burnt wax and wet stone. Small stones were still falling, ticking down the rock, and the lamp that Tamsin had carried lay on its side in the grass with its flame streaming sideways like a banner.

"Girl," he said. He could not hear himself. "*Girl.*"

She was beside him, on her face in the mud. He turned her over with shaking hands. Her eyes were closed. Her mouth was open. A thread of blood ran from her nose, and she was breathing,

fast and shallow, and when he laid his palm on her chest he felt, under the thin wet cloth, a heart going like a bird's.

Her lips moved. She was still humming.

He put his forehead against hers and wept.

Rook was on his hands and knees by the crater, with his head hanging and blood running from his left ear in a bright steady stream down his neck. He did not look up when Caelen shouted. He did not look up when Malakar, bent double a few yards off with one arm round the Engineer-Captain's neck, lifted a hand and waved. He knelt there swaying, staring at the earth between his palms, and when Caelen reached him and gripped his shoulder he turned his head, slowly, with a puzzled expression, like a man who has heard his name called from a long way off.

"I can't," he said, loudly. "Caelen. I can't hear the — it's all on one side. It's all gone on this side."

"I know. It's all right."

"It's not *right.* There's no —" He broke off. He put his hand to the ear and brought it away red and looked at it. "Oh," he said, quite calmly. "That's blood."

"Sit down."

"I'm fine. I'm fine, I'm — go on. Go and look." He shoved at Caelen with the flat of his hand. "I'm *fine,* damn you, go!"

Corwin was on his knees at the lip of the crater, his good grey coat in rags, with his left arm clasped to his chest and his face the color of paper. Beside him was a block of stone as big as a hearth. It had come off the boulder in the blast and fallen across the mouth of the gallery that led down to the niche, and Corwin, who had not been a brave man all his life, who had said so, laughingly, in a tall thin house in the Spire, had put his arm under it. He had held it, for one slow terrible second, until the others got clear. Something had broken. The wrist was bent where no wrist should bend. He was smiling, in a ghastly sort of way, and shaking.

"It's nothing," he said, thinly. "It's a — I think it's just a — don't *look* at it."

"Corwin."

"There are two in there." His voice rose. "Caelen. There are two that are fine, I could see them, the glass is cracked but they're — and there was a third. There were *three,* and one's —" He stopped, and swallowed, and pointed with his chin toward the edge. "It was thrown."

He found the third pocket by the sound.

It was below the cliff. The slope fell away in steps of black rock to a narrow shelf awash with spray, and beyond the shelf, at the foot of the headland, a cave opened in the stone: a sea-cave, a half-drowned hollow with the surf boiling white at its mouth. The blast had thrown the third sleeper out of the niche and down the slope, and he lay in the wash of the waves with his back across a rock, a small naked thing in the froth, and he was making a noise.

It was not a scream. It was thinner than that. It was a thin high unbroken wail, on one note, without breath or pause, like wind in a keyhole. The honey stone that had held him lay round him in shards. His eyes were open. They were enormous, and gold, and utterly without sense. His small hands clawed at the rock. His whole body was jerking, in great shuddering convulsions, in rhythm with the sea.

That's me, Caelen thought. *That's me, in the mine.*

He went down the slope on his heels and his hands, sliding, tearing his palms on the rock, and reached the shelf, and the sea took him to the knees. It was freezing. It beat at him like a fist. He dropped down in the water beside the child and did what he had done all his life: he put his back to the storm, and took the thing in his arms.

The boy bucked and clawed. A nail raked his cheek. He held on, and said in a voice that he could not hear, *I have you. Hold. I have you.*

It did no good.

The child was beyond words. He was beyond anything but pain. He was drowning in the first moment of his life, in the dark, in the roar, alone, and the thing in Caelen's chest, the small banked coal, the held breath, began to answer, because it knew exactly what this was. It was rising. He felt it come up through his ribs. He felt the old undertow reach for him, vast and patient, and for the first time in his life he did not fight it, because he knew now what it was. It was the other half of him. It was the part that had never been let out.

A broken cradle breaks the child, he thought. *Then be the cradle.*

He opened his mouth and sang.

It took everything.

He had thought he knew what that meant. He had spent nine days on a ledge, with a note in his throat and a bank of coals in his chest, and he had believed it was the limit. It was nothing. It was a rehearsal. In the freezing froth of the sea-cave, with the boy screaming in his arms and the storm tearing at his hair, he let go of every hold he had ever kept on himself, the banking and the rationing and the long cold discipline of ten years, and poured it out.

He gave the child his warmth. He gave him his weight, his hands, his arms, his name. He gave him the coal, all of it, the whole vast patient hunger that had stood at the edge of every Shift in his life, and it went from him in a long bright rush like water out of a broken jar. He felt it go. He felt the cold come in behind it, a cold such as he had never known, the cold of an empty house.

Hold, he sang. *Hold. I'm here. Hold.*

And across the water, from the ledge above, thin and clear and unbearably steady, a second voice came down to meet his.

She had followed. She stood on the lip of the slope in the screaming wind, with the blood still on her upper lip and her small drenched shape black against the lightning, and her voice came down

out of the dark and joined his, a half-step above, and together they made the chord. The child in his arms went rigid. His wail faltered. It wavered on its single note.

And then, one by one, along the cliff, the lights came.

They came down the headland in the dark with the storm at their backs: Nessa, with her oil-can and her net-needle; and her people behind her, the lamp families, nine of them, and then more, the net-menders and fishwives and boys with goats, a long straggling line of small lights on the black cliff, each one a tin-hooded lantern held up against the wind. They came down the slope without speaking. They stood in a ring on the shelf, round the child and the man and the sea, with the surf breaking at their boots. And in her cracked old voice, Nessa began to tell the tide.

Low water in two hours. The wind is south and strong. The sea is high. It will not come above this stone.

It was the oldest thing in the harbor. It was what a lamp-keeper said to a sleeper in the dark so that the dark would not be empty. One by one the others took it up. A man's voice. A woman's. The chant went round the ring, soft and low and ragged, under the howl of the gale: *the wind is south, the sea is calm, the lamp is lit, you are not alone.*

The boy stopped screaming.

It did not happen all at once. It came by degrees, in a slow subsiding, like a pot taken off a fire. His eyes found the lanterns. They found the faces. They found, last, the small girl standing on the rock above him, humming, with her hands out. His mouth worked. A sound came out of it, the very first sound of its kind, three tones and a fall.

And at the edge of the ring, in his salt-stiff coat, with his hat in his hand and the rain running down his face, the Brine-Reeve of the third harbor went down on his knees in the sea.

"Give him to me," said Hask. "Give him here."

Caelen did not hear him. He had stopped hearing. The cold had reached his heart, and the dark behind it was soft, and in the very last instant before it took him he felt something go in his chest, quietly, like a latch lifting, like a held breath let out at last. It did not hurt. It was only a great stillness, and a great release. And as he went down into it with a child's hand in his, he thought, with perfect clarity, *oh. That's what it was for.*

Chapter Eleven — What the Coast Remembers

He woke on the fourth day, in a clean white bed, and the first thing he noticed was that he was not cold.

It was so strange that he lay quite still for a long time, looking at the ceiling, trying to find the shape of it. It was the infirmary on the upper floor of the tide-house, the room with the open window. The light was grey and soft. Outside, gulls were crying over a calm sea, and the sound of hammering came up from the quay, and somewhere in the next room a child was humming, thin and tuneless, over and over, the same three tones and a fall. He had been cold every waking hour of his life since a mountain split open. It had never left him, not once. He had banked it and rationed it and eaten against it and wrapped himself against it, a cold that lived in the bone, and now it was gone, and in its place lay a quiet so wide that he did not know where to put his hands.

“You’re awake,” said Tamsin.

She was in the chair by the bed with a blanket over her knees and her black book open on it, and a smear of ink on her cheek that had been there so long it was nearly a feature. Her braid had come undone. She looked as though she had not slept in a week. She looked, he thought, quite wonderful.

“How long?”

“Four days. The storm blew out the second night. We thought you’d —” She stopped, and pressed the heel of her hand to her mouth, and took it away. “We’ve been taking turns. The girl wouldn’t leave. She sat on the end of the bed for two days with that horse. Seraphina made her eat.”

“The boy?”

"Alive. He's down the hall. He's —" Her face did something helpless. "He sings. All day. He's learned the Reeve's name and he says it at him. Hask comes every morning and sits there. I don't think he's said more than ten words."

"And the others?"

"Two in the Drowned Bell. Still in the glass. The cracks held. Seraphina says the shell has to be sealed before the next tide and she thinks it can be, with — with what you showed us. With the song." A pause. "She says nobody's to be woken until they're ready. She says it's what the wall means by *don't hurry.* She's been sitting with them every night."

He closed his eyes.

It was all right, then. It was all right. He lay in the white bed in the grey light and felt the thing go through him, slowly, like warmth into numb fingers, and did not know whether it was grief or joy or simple exhaustion. He had held. They had held. The cliff was still there. Rook was alive and Corwin was alive and the girl was alive and a boy of nine, in the room next door, was learning a Reeve's name.

He put his hand flat on his chest, over the place where the bank had been. It was quiet. It was warm. It was only a chest.

They had decided it without him.

That was the first thing Malakar told him, in the afternoon, sitting on the end of the bed with a cup of something black. The council had met on the day after the storm, in the tide-house, with the wind still blowing the shutters. It had not taken long. Hask had not spoken. He had walked in, still in his salt-stiff coat, with the boy's blood on the sleeve, and had stood at the head of the black oak table, and laid his father's key on it.

It was an iron key, as long as a man's hand, black with age. It opened a door in the cliff nobody had ever found. The Reeve had put it down beside the lead box and said, "I will not vote. I am not fit." A pause. "But I will tell you what I know. I know that the vow was *we'll not wake what we can't keep.* I know that I have kept for twenty-six years and I did not keep him. A stranger did that. A stranger, and a child, and the whole harbor in the rain with lamps." His great shoulders had shaken. "I should like to learn how."

The vote was ten to one. The shipwright had abstained, with dignity, and then voted aye.

"What did they decide?" said Caelen.

"To open the Ledger." Malakar turned his cup. "To enter the sleepers on the roll, publicly, under the hall's finding, by name, where there is a name, and by note where there is none. To wake them, a pocket at a time, in the open, with the rite, and a physician, and the lamp families, as many as wish to sit. To accept the Guild's money in escrow under the Ledger's seal, and refuse every other thing it offers. The Engineer-Captain's party will be sent south on the first fair tide, with a letter." He glanced up. "Reth wrote it himself."

"What does it say?"

"That Captain Halse is dismissed from the service of the Mining Guild for firing a charge in defiance of the Chairman's written order, and that the Board is requested to note that the order was lawful and the defiance was not." A dry breath. "It is the kindest document I have ever seen end a career."

"Halse?"

"Is in the cells under the quay. Not by anyone's wish. He asked." Malakar's voice was quite level. "He sat in the infirmary for two nights, outside the boy's door, and did not speak. On the third he asked to be locked up. I think he wanted to be somewhere where he could not do anything."

Caelen was quiet for a time.

"I don't hate him," he said.

"No. Nor does the Chairman." Malakar finished his cup. "That is the thing about this affair that I should have liked to explain to myself at twenty-five. There is no villain. There is only a very large, very reasonable machine, and a small number of people who have decided, one by one, to stop being part of it."

They gave him the afternoon to get up.

He walked the length of the quay, slowly, with Rook on one side and the girl on the other, and every person he passed took off their cap.

He bore it better than he would have a month ago. He did not know why. He walked in the thin gold light with his hand on a child's shoulder, and the harbor opened round him, the white houses, the green water, the nets spread on the stones to dry. The lamp-keepers were on the cliff, trimming their wicks in broad daylight, and when Nessa saw him she raised her net-needle, once, like a salute, and went back to her work.

"Rook." He said it softly. "Can you hear me?"

"Right side only." Rook tapped his left ear. "Seraphina says it won't come back. Not all of it. A bit, maybe." He grinned crookedly. "It's got an advantage. If you mumble at me from the wrong side I can pretend I didn't hear."

"I'm sorry."

"Shut up." But his voice cracked. "Shut up, Caelen. I'd pay the price again. I'd pay it for the kid."

Corwin sat on a barrel at the end of the quay with his arm in a sling of tarred canvas and a pencil in his other hand, writing a letter to Lisbet in a vile scrawl. He looked up, saw them coming, and held up the page. *Dear Lis,* it began. *I have broken my wrist. It is the single bravest thing I have ever done and it was entirely an accident. I am coming home soon. The kettle had better be on.*

"I've been thinking," Corwin said, "of settling here."

"You're a Spire noble."

"I was a second son with a mended cuff." He looked out over the harbor. "I never had a house of my own. I think I should like to have one with a view of the sea, and a green door, and a sign over it that says *come in.*" A faint wry smile. "I'm told the harbor is short of clerks."

Vesh found him on the way back.

The Harbor-Master was standing at the door of the tide-house with the great Ledger open in his arms, as if he had just carried it down the steps. His spectacles were pushed up in his hair. He wore no coat. In the plain blue shirt, with his sleeves rolled and a smear of ink to the elbow, he looked ten years younger.

"I've been counting," he said. "You will forgive me. I could not stop."

He turned the Ledger round, and Caelen looked down.

It was the page at the back. It had been ruled in the old columns, in the neat angular hand of the clerks, and the margin down the outer edge was black with little tally-strokes: a hundred and nine of them, in rows, grouped in fives. But beside the first of them, in new ink, someone had drawn a line through the stroke and written beside it, in Vesh's own exact shaking hand, a long low curve that climbed in the middle and bent over to a final soft peak, and the word *awake.* And beside the second, a smaller curve, and *awake, the Long Shelf.* And beside the third, with a date: *The Drowned Bell. The Reeve's boy.*

There were three of them. The rest were still strokes.

"I shall do it a line at a time," Vesh said. "It will take me the rest of my life. I find I do not mind." His voice shook. "Nineteen years I believed I was keeping the dead. I am told it is the best news the Keeper of the Deep Ledger has had in three hundred years."

"What will you do with the strokes?"

"Cross them out." He looked up. "One by one. As they are woken. And write what I am told." A trembling smile. "I should like it recorded, Mister Caelen, that I did not need the Chairman's money, or the hall's finding, or the Guild's seal. I needed someone to sit down on a floor and be quiet. You did that. And they came out."

Caelen could not answer. He stood on the steps in the thin light with the girl's hand in his, and for a long moment the only sound in the world was the sea, and the child at his side, humming.

It was a note he knew. It was the three tones and a fall. And under it, so quiet that he almost missed it, was another sound, one he had never heard: the plain, ordinary, empty ring of his own breath, in a chest where something used to burn.

Chapter Twelve — The Salt Coast, Wider

Seraphina asked him to try on the sixth day, and he already knew what would happen.

They did it in the infirmary, behind a closed door, with the afternoon light coming in across the boards and the sea breathing under the windows. She had not wanted to ask. He could see that. She sat in the chair opposite him with her hands folded very tightly in her lap and said, in the careful voice she used for things that were going to hurt, “I think you should find out. Whatever it is. I would rather you knew, with me here, than discovered it in the middle of a fight.”

“I know already.”

“Then show me.”

He held out his right hand, palm up, and closed his eyes, and reached for the place behind his sternum where the bank had lain for ten years. He knew the way. He had known it in his sleep. It was a door in the dark, and beyond it the coal, a small hot weight, banked and watchful, the vast patient hunger that had stood at the edge of every Shift he had ever made. He walked toward it as he had walked toward it a thousand times, and put his hand on the latch.

There was no latch.

There was nothing. There was a quiet, warm, empty room with sunlight in it, and the faint smell of salt. He stood in it a long while. He felt for the old weight, the pressure, the cold. He felt for the Drift, and the hunger, and the long slow pull of the dark. He found only himself, a man with ordinary hands, breathing in a chair.

He opened his eyes. The hand lay palm up on his knee, brown and scarred and entirely human. The nails were short. They did not thicken. The fingers did not lengthen. The air above them did not warm.

“I see,” said Seraphina, very softly.

“It’s gone.”

“Not gone.” She leaned forward. Her eyes were wet. “Finished. I think that is the word. The held breath was the coal. They were one thing. You gave all of it to that child in the surf, and the waking completed, and there was nothing left to hold.” She took a breath. “You will not Shift again, Caelen. I do not think you can. You are not drifting, and you will never drift. You are not hungry in the old way. You are not in danger of yourself. You are only —”

“Woken.”

“Yes.”

He sat with that. It was a great relief. It was the greatest relief of his life, and it frightened him more than anything that had ever happened to him, because he had spent ten years believing that he was a weapon with a safety catch, and he had been, and it was gone. He thought of a forest. He thought of a weigh-station, a flooded cellar, a Vault. He thought of a man in a fallen tree saying *whatever in the nine hells you are.* He thought: *I do not know what I am for.*

“It is not a loss,” Seraphina said, as if she had heard. “It is only a change of shape.”

“I know.”

“Do you?”

He looked at his hand, for a long time. Then he laughed, short and cracked, and put it over his eyes.

“No,” he said. “But I’m going to find out.”

The cold did not come back.

It was the oddest thing about the next weeks, and the one he never quite got used to. He ate when he was hungry, and stopped when he was not. He slept through the night and woke at dawn. He could stand in a wind without bracing. He caught himself, once, walking across the quay in the early light with nothing in his pockets, no strip of dried meat, no ration, and stopped dead in the middle of the stones, and had to stand there a minute until the feeling went.

He could not feel the cliff.

That was harder. He went out to the headland on the ninth evening, alone, and lay on his stomach at the edge as he had on the first day, and put his palm flat on the gravel. He felt cold stone and wet grass. He felt the wind. He felt the sea, a great distant weight, and the long slow patience of the headland in the dusk, and nothing in it that spoke. The pulse was gone. The hundred and six that still slept, in their niches, under their little lamps, had not stopped. They were there. They were warm, he knew it, as one knows a house is lived in. But he could no longer hear them.

He lay there until it was dark, with his hand on the stone, and cried a little, not for himself, quite.

And then, from somewhere behind him, at the end of the road, a small voice began to hum.

She was on the harbor wall.

He found her there at dusk, the next evening, when the lamps were coming on along the quay and the water was the color of tarnished silver. She sat at the very end, where the breakwater curved out into the roads, with her legs hanging over the drop and the wooden horse in her lap, looking at the sea. She had grown. He saw it in the pale light. She was taller than she had been in June. Her hair had come in thick and dark, with a gleam of gold in it, and the cut-down smock had been replaced by a real dress, a blue one, that Tamsin had sewn.

She did not turn when he came. She went on humming.

It was her name. He knew it before he was near enough to hear the shape. It was that long low curve that climbed in the middle and bent over to a soft peak, the one she had sung from the threshold of the white house with the whole cliff answering. She sang it quietly, to nobody, to the sea. The tide ran under the wall. The lights of the *Tally* hung at anchor beyond the boom, and behind them, a long way off, a few late gulls turned over the green dark.

He sat down beside her.

She looked at him. Her eyes were gold in the lamplight. She regarded his chest, from habit, with her head a little tilted, and then his face, and a small frown came between her brows.

"Quiet," she said. It was one of her new words. She had perhaps three hundred now.

"Yes."

"Gone?"

"Yes." He swallowed. "But I'm all right. I'm —" He found he did not have the word, and tried another. "I'm *here.*"

She considered it, gravely. Then she put out her small brown hand and laid it flat on his sternum, where the coal had been, and held it there, and he waited for the hum. It did not come. She sat very still, with her palm on his chest, listening. And then her face cleared, as if she had heard something he could not, and she took her hand away and folded it in her lap and nodded once, with great satisfaction.

"Good," she said.

He had thought about what to say for twenty-two days at sea, and for a hundred more on the stair, and he found, when it came to it, that he did not need any of it.

The light was going. The sea lay quiet. Behind them, up the long black stair of the town, the windows of the white houses were coming on one by one like a held breath let out. Somewhere up there a boy was singing the Reeve's name. Somewhere a woman was telling the tide. Somewhere Seraphina was sitting with two sleepers in a cracked glass, and Rook was laughing at something from the wrong side of his head, and a man with a mended cuff was writing a letter to his sister.

He thought of a forest. He thought of a spider rebuilding its web in the rain. He thought of a man's unhurried boots going away through the green, and the fact that they had not once slowed, or turned, to see.

"I want to tell you something," he said.

She looked at him.

"A man found me, once. A long time ago. I was in a tree, and I was hungry, and I was very afraid. He gave me meat. He said, *come down.* He never looked back to see whether I was following." The words came slowly. "For nine years he told me it was arithmetic. It wasn't. It was the other thing. He just didn't have the word. I didn't either, until I met you."

She said nothing. She had folded her hands in her lap.

"You were never a debt," he said. "I want you to know. You were never anything I was owed, or that I owed, or that anybody did anything for because of what you are. You were just *you.* I'd have crossed the sea for nothing. I'd have sat on that floor a year." His voice cracked. "I don't know what you are. I don't know what I am. I don't know what happens now. But I'm glad you came down. I'm glad you ate."

She was quiet for a long time. Then she leaned her head against his arm, with a weight like a bird's, and said, in her hoarse, cracked, careful voice:

"Stay."

"Yes," said Caelen. "I'm staying."

The letter came at dusk the next day, carried down the quay by Tam, who stopped, and bowed, and said that the Chairman had asked him to give it into Mister Caelen's own hand.

It was a single sheet, folded small. It was in Reth's clear dry script.

Halse has given me his survey notes. I had not asked. He sat in the cells for ten days and wrote them out, because he said he could not bear to keep them. I am sending them to Kell in the Spire, and a copy to the Hall of Canon. I thought you should know first.

The party that surveyed the third harbor in the spring was one of six. The Board's Charter 9 ran along the whole of the western seaboard. There are other coasts. Halse's notes name four hundred and eleven seams with a periodic pulse, from the Salt Coast to the southern capes. He does not know how many are occupied.

I do not think it is a number any of us will be able to enter in a ledger.

— R.

He read it twice. Then he folded it along its crease and put it in his coat, beside a brass token he had never spent, and looked up at the cliff.

It was dark. The lamps were burning. All along the headland, in their tin hoods, forty-one small gold flames burned steadily in the dusk like a string of patient eyes, and under them, in the stone,

a hundred and six hearts beat on. Some of them would wake in the spring. Some in the summer after. Some, perhaps, would have to wait for a hand that had not yet been born.

The girl was at his side. She had followed him down the quay, quietly, as she followed him everywhere now, and stood with her wooden horse under her arm, looking up at the cliff. He looked down at her. Her face in the lamplight was serious, and open, and entirely unafraid.

She hummed a note.

It was not her name. It was the first line of the long song, the one on the wall. And from the dark headland, very faintly, from a hundred and six places at once, the cliff hummed back.

He could not hear it. He knew that. But he saw her smile.

"All right," said Caelen, and took her hand. "Then let's go and tell them."